Motivic Homotopy Theory (Draft)

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Preface

These notes grew out of my participation in Marc Hoyois's Oberseminar on motivic cohomology at the University of Regensburg (SoSe 2026), combined with my own study of the subject. The primary references are the work of Bachmann–Hoyois [BH21] on norms, and the recent paper of Bachmann–Elmanto–Morrow [BEM25].

The goal is to give a self-contained introduction to motivic homotopy theory.

Warning. *This document is a preliminary draft. It likely contains errors, incomplete arguments, and missing references. In particular, some parts of this document were drafted with AI assistance, which may have introduced inaccurate or fabricated citations; readers who notice such discrepancies are encouraged to contact the author. Corrections and suggestions are always welcome.*

Conventions

Throughout these notes, we work in the framework of ∞-categories. The word "category" means ∞-category unless otherwise specified; we write "ordinary category" or "1-category" for the classical notion.

All schemes are assumed to be quasi-compact and quasi-separated unless otherwise stated.

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Chapter 1.

Unstable Motivic Homotopy Theory

The starting point of motivic homotopy theory is a striking analogy between algebraic geometry and topology. In topology, for any paracompact Hausdorff space X, the projection $X \times I \to X$ (with $I = [0,1]$) induces a bijection

$$\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r^{\mathrm{top}}(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r^{\mathrm{top}}(X \times I).$$

Vector bundles, and many other invariants, are insensitive to the cylinder direction. The classical Quillen–Suslin theorem [Qui76, Sus76] provides the algebraic counterpart: every finitely generated projective module over $k[x_1, \ldots, x_n]$ is free, equivalently, the pullback

$$\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r(\mathrm{Spec}(k)) \xrightarrow{\sim} \pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r(\mathbb{A}^n_k)$$

is a bijection. Under this analogy, the affine line $\mathbb{A}^1$ plays the role of the interval I: both serve as "cylinder objects" in their respective categories, suggesting a homotopy theory for algebraic geometry in which the projection $\mathbb{A}^1 \times X \to X$ is declared a homotopy equivalence.

Supporting this intuition, many cohomology theories on smooth schemes are $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant. For a smooth scheme X over a field k:

- **Chow groups:** $\mathrm{CH}^*(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{CH}^*(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$;
- **Grothendieck group:** $\mathrm{K}_0(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{K}_0(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$;
- **Étale cohomology** (for ℓ invertible in k): $\mathrm{H}^*_{\text{ét}}(X, \mu_\ell) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{H}^*_{\text{ét}}(X \times \mathbb{A}^1, \mu_\ell)$.

***Remark* 1.0.1** ($\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance fails on non-affine schemes)**.** The functor $\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_r \colon \mathsf{Sm}_k^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Set}$ is *not* $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant in general. Take the rank-2 bundle E on $\mathbb{P}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1$ obtained by gluing the trivial bundle on the standard charts $U_0 = \mathrm{Spec}(k[x]) \times \mathbb{A}^1$ and $U_1 = \mathrm{Spec}(k[x^{-1}]) \times \mathbb{A}^1$ via the transition matrix

$$g_{01}(x,t) = \begin{pmatrix} x & t \\ 0 & x^{-1} \end{pmatrix} \in \mathrm{GL}_2\big(k[x, x^{-1}, t]\big).$$

At $t = 0$, the matrix is diagonal, giving $E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{0\}} \simeq \mathcal{O}(1) \oplus \mathcal{O}(-1)$. At $t = 1$, the matrix defines a non-trivial extension

$$0 \longrightarrow \mathcal{O}(-1) \longrightarrow E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{1\}} \longrightarrow \mathcal{O}(1) \longrightarrow 0$$

whose class in $\mathrm{Ext}^1(\mathcal{O}(1), \mathcal{O}(-1)) = H^1(\mathbb{P}^1, \mathcal{O}(-2)) \cong k$ is non-zero; by Grothendieck's splitting theorem, this extension is isomorphic as a vector bundle to $\mathcal{O} \oplus \mathcal{O}$. Since $E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{0\}} \not\simeq E|_{\mathbb{P}^1 \times \{1\}}$ on $\mathbb{P}^1$, the bundle E cannot lie in the image of $\pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_2(\mathbb{P}^1) \to \pi_0 \mathsf{Vect}_2(\mathbb{P}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1)$.

Nevertheless—and this is the deep theorem of Morel [Mor12], simplified by Asok–Hoyois–Wendt [AHW17]—if we forcibly $\mathbb{A}^1$-localize Vect_r, the resulting functor still computes the correct values on *smooth affine* schemes. This affine representability theorem is one of the cornerstone applications of motivic homotopy theory.

Overview of the construction. Fix a quasi-compact quasi-separated scheme S, and let Sm_S denote the category of smooth S-schemes of finite presentation. Our goal is to construct the **motivic homotopy category** $\mathsf{H}(S)$: an enlargement of Sm_S in which the projections $\mathbb{A}^1 \times_S X \to X$ become equivalences. The construction proceeds in three universal steps, each with a clear geometric meaning:

(i) **Sifted cocompletion.** Embed Sm_S into $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$, the category of presheaves of anima that convert finite coproducts to finite products.

(ii) **Nisnevich descent.** Force a chosen class of étale-like covers (the *Nisnevich covers*) to become equivalences, yielding $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$.

(iii) **$\mathbb{A}^1$-localization.** Force the projections $\mathbb{A}^1 \times X \to X$ to become equivalences, yielding the motivic homotopy category $\mathsf{H}(S)$.

***Remark* 1.0.2** (Why $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$ rather than PShv?)**.** One could equally well start from the full presheaf category $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$. The advantage of $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ is threefold:

(i) Since Sm_S is extensive, $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}_\sqcup(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ [BH21, Lemma 2.4], which is already a topos for the coproduct topology.

(ii) The Yoneda embedding $\mathsf{Sm}_S \hookrightarrow \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ preserves finite coproducts, and every object is a sifted colimit of representables.

(iii) The universal property of $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$ as the free sifted cocompletion is essential to the construction of norm functors in Appendix A; see [BH21, §3].

Since finite coproduct decompositions are themselves Nisnevich covers, we have natural inclusions

$$\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S),$$

and we write $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \colon \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \to \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ for the Nisnevich sheafification functor.

1.1. The Nisnevich Topology

The Nisnevich topology, also called the completely decomposed topology, sits strictly between Zariski and étale. In motivic homotopy theory, this choice is forced by two complementary optimality conditions: it is the coarsest topology for which the purity theorem holds, and the finest for which algebraic K-theory is representable (Remark 1.1.1).

1.1.1. Three topologies

For S qcqs, there are three commonly used Grothendieck topologies on Sm_S:

$$\mathrm{Zar} \subset \mathrm{Nis} \subset \text{ét}.$$

- **Zariski:** covers are jointly surjective open immersions.
- **Étale:** covers are jointly surjective étale morphisms.
- **Nisnevich:** covers are jointly surjective étale morphisms with the additional requirement that no residue field extensions occur.

The functor-of-points perspective makes the Nisnevich condition transparent. For a smooth k-scheme X, an étale cover $\{U_i \to X\}$ need not satisfy $\coprod_i U_i(k) \twoheadrightarrow X(k)$: the preimage of a k-rational point might only exist over a finite separable extension L/k. A Nisnevich cover excludes precisely this phenomenon—every k-rational point lifts without field extension.

***Remark* 1.1.1** (Why Nisnevich?)**.** The Nisnevich topology is characterized by two complementary optimality conditions:

- **Coarsest topology for which purity holds.** The purity theorem asserts that for a closed immersion $Z \hookrightarrow X$ in Sm_S with normal bundle ν_Z, there is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence $X/(X \setminus Z) \simeq \mathrm{Th}(\nu_Z)$. The Zariski topology is too coarse for this.
- **Finest topology for which K-theory is representable.** Non-connective K-theory $\mathrm{K} \colon \mathsf{Sm}_S^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Sp}$ satisfies Nisnevich descent but not étale descent.

1.1.2. Nisnevich covers

Definition 1.1.2 (Nisnevich cover). A family of étale morphisms $(f_i : U_i \to X)_{i \in I}$ in Sm_S is a **Nisnevich cover** if for every $x \in X$, there exists $i \in I$ and $u \in U_i$ with $f_i(u) = x$ and $\kappa(u) \xrightarrow{\sim} \kappa(x)$.

***Remark* 1.1.3.** The term "completely decomposed" originates in arithmetic: a prime ideal $\mathfrak{p}$ of $\mathcal{O}_K$ is "completely decomposed" in an étale cover precisely when its residue field does not extend.

Theorem 1.1.4 (Equivalent characterizations). *Let X be qcqs and $(f_i : U_i \to X)_{i \in I}$ a family of étale morphisms. The following are equivalent:*

(i) ***(Rational points)*** *For every $x \in X$, there exists i and $u \in U_i$ with $f_i(u) = x$ and $\kappa(u) \xrightarrow{\sim} \kappa(x)$.*

(ii) ***(Finite stratification)*** *There is a chain of finitely presented closed subschemes*

$$\varnothing = Z_0 \subset Z_1 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n = X$$

such that some f_i admits a section over each stratum $Y_j = Z_j \setminus Z_{j-1}$.

(iii) ***(Refinement by Nisnevich squares)*** *There is a stratification as above and a finitely presented étale family $(g_j : V_j \to X)_{j=1}^n$ refining (f_i), with each g_j restricting to an isomorphism over Y_j.*

Proof. The implications (iii) $\Rightarrow$ (ii) $\Rightarrow$ (i) are immediate. We prove (i) $\Rightarrow$ (iii).

Replacing each U_i by an affine open cover, we may assume all U_i are quasi-compact and separated, hence all f_i are of finite presentation. Consider the collection of closed subschemes $Y \subseteq X$ for which (iii) fails; we show this collection is empty by Zorn's lemma.

Let $(Y_\alpha)_{\alpha \in A}$ be a descending chain and $Y = \bigcap_\alpha Y_\alpha$. If (iii) holds for Y, then by finite presentation it holds for some Y_α (limits of finitely presented data along cofiltered systems). Hence if (iii) fails, there exists a minimal closed $Y \subseteq X$ for which it fails. Replacing X by Y, we may assume (iii) fails for X but holds for all proper closed subschemes.

Clearly $X \neq \varnothing$. Take a generic point $x \in X$. By (i), for some i there is a morphism $\operatorname{Spec}(\kappa(x)) \to U_i$ lifting $\operatorname{Spec}(\kappa(x)) \to X$. Since $\mathcal{O}_{X,x}^{\mathrm{red}} = \kappa(x)$, the nilpotent lifting property of étale morphisms yields a lift $\operatorname{Spec}(\mathcal{O}_{X,x}) \to U_i$. Passing to a limit, we obtain a quasi-compact open neighborhood $V \subseteq X$ of x and a section $s : V \to U_i$.

Take a finitely presented closed $Z \subset X$ with $V = X \setminus Z$. By minimality, (iii) holds for Z: there is a stratification $\varnothing = Z_0 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n = Z$ and a refining family $(h_j : W_j \to Z)$ with the required properties. For each j, lift W_j to a finitely presented open $V_j \subseteq U_{i_j}$ with $g_j : V_j \to X$ étale and an isomorphism over Y_j. Extending the chain to $\varnothing = Z_0 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n \subset Z_{n+1} = X$ with $V_{n+1} = V$ and $g_{n+1} = f_i \circ s$ realizes (iii) for X, contradicting minimality. □

1.1.3. Nisnevich squares

The key feature of the Nisnevich topology in practice is that it is generated by a particularly simple class of covers.

Definition 1.1.5 (Nisnevich square). A pullback square in Sm_S

$$\begin{tikzcd} U \times_X V \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & V \arrow[d, "p"] \\ U \arrow[r, hook, "j"'] & X \end{tikzcd}$$

is a **Nisnevich square** if

- j is an open immersion;
- p is étale;
- p induces an isomorphism $p^{-1}(X \setminus U)_{\mathrm{red}} \xrightarrow{\sim} (X \setminus U)_{\mathrm{red}}$.

From the functor-of-points perspective, a Nisnevich square decomposes X's R-points into two classes: those landing in the open U, handled by j; and those in the closed complement $X \setminus U$, covered by p without any residue field extension.

Lemma 1.1.6. *The family $\{j\colon U \hookrightarrow X,\ p\colon V \to X\}$ is a Nisnevich cover of X.*

Proof. For $x \in U$, j has x in its image with trivial residue extension. For $x \in X \setminus U$, the assumption gives $v \in p^{-1}(x)$ with $\kappa(v) \simeq \kappa(x)$. □

The deeper result is that Nisnevich squares *generate* the Nisnevich topology:

Proposition 1.1.7 (Brown–Gersten). *A ($\mathcal{D}$-valued) presheaf $\mathcal{F}$ on Sm_S is a Nisnevich sheaf if and only if $\mathcal{F}(\varnothing)$ is terminal and $\mathcal{F}$ sends every Nisnevich square to a pullback square:*

$$\mathcal{F}(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}(V) \times_{\mathcal{F}(U \times_X V)} \mathcal{F}(U).$$

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) By Lemma 1.1.6, $\{U \hookrightarrow X, V \to X\}$ is a Nisnevich cover, and the sheaf condition directly yields the claimed pullback square. Applying the sheaf condition to the empty cover of $\varnothing$ shows that $\mathcal{F}(\varnothing)$ is terminal.

($\Leftarrow$) Assume $\mathcal{F}$ sends Nisnevich squares to pullbacks. We show that $\mathcal{F}$ satisfies the sheaf condition for any Nisnevich cover of X. By Theorem 1.1.4(iii), there is a refining family $(g_i\colon V_i \to X)_{i=1}^n$ together with a stratification $\varnothing = Z_0 \subset \cdots \subset Z_n = X$ such that each g_i is an isomorphism over Y_i. We proceed by induction on n.

For $n = 0$, we have $X = \varnothing$, and the hypothesis on $\mathcal{F}(\varnothing)$ gives the result. For $n \geq 1$, set $U = X \setminus Z_1$, so that the inclusion $\iota\colon U \hookrightarrow X$ is an open immersion with complement Z_1. Since g_1 is an isomorphism over Z_1, the pair $\{U \hookrightarrow X,\ V_1 \to X\}$ forms a Nisnevich square, giving

$$\mathcal{F}(X) \simeq \mathcal{F}(V_1) \times_{\mathcal{F}(U \times_X V_1)} \mathcal{F}(U).$$

The induced stratification on U has length $n-1$, so by the inductive hypothesis $\mathcal{F}$ satisfies descent for the induced covers of U and of $U \times_X V_1$. Pasting pullbacks finishes the proof. □

***Warning* 1.1.8** (Non-subcanonicality). The Nisnevich topology is *not* subcanonical: representable presheaves $y(X) = \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{Sm}_S}(-, X)$ are in general not Nisnevich sheaves. Concretely, Nisnevich descent for h_X would require X-points to glue along Nisnevich covers, but this already fails for henselizations: the henselian local ring $\mathcal{O}^h_{Y,y}$ is the colimit of étale neighborhoods of y, yet $X(\mathcal{O}^h_{Y,y})$ generally does *not* agree with $\operatorname{colim} X(U)$ over those neighborhoods unless X is sufficiently rigid.

Consequently, throughout the construction of $\mathsf{H}(S)$ we must Nisnevich-sheafify representables before working with them. The same warning applies, a fortiori, to the cdh topology of §**??**.

1.1.4. Examples

Example 1.1.9 (Zariski covers are Nisnevich). Open immersions induce identity maps on residue fields, so Zariski covers are automatically Nisnevich. The standard cover $\{\mathbb{A}^1, \mathbb{A}^1\} \to \mathbb{P}^1$ corresponds to the Nisnevich square

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[d] \\ \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[r] & \mathbb{P}^1. \end{tikzcd}$$

Example 1.1.10 (The m-th power map). Let k be a field with $\mathrm{char}(k) \nmid m$ and $a \in k^\times$. Consider

$$\begin{aligned} f\colon (\mathbb{A}^1 \setminus \{a\}) \sqcup (\mathbb{A}^1 \setminus \{0\}) &\longrightarrow \mathbb{A}^1, \\ \text{first component:}\quad x &\longmapsto x, \\ \text{second component:}\quad y &\longmapsto y^m. \end{aligned}$$

The first component is an open immersion; the second is étale. This f is a Nisnevich cover if and only if a has an m-th root in k.

Example 1.1.11 (Algebraic K-theory is a Nisnevich sheaf). By Brown–Gersten it suffices to check Nisnevich excision (the empty case is trivial). For a Nisnevich square

$$\begin{tikzcd} W \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & V \arrow[d] \\ U \arrow[r, "j"'] & Y, \end{tikzcd}$$

perfect complexes satisfy flat descent, so we obtain a pullback square of stable categories

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathsf{Perf}(W) & \mathsf{Perf}(V) \arrow[l] \\ \mathsf{Perf}(U) \arrow[u] & \mathsf{Perf}(Y). \arrow[l] \arrow[u] \end{tikzcd}$$

Setting $Z = Y \setminus U = V \setminus W$ and taking horizontal fibers gives a diagram of Karoubi sequences (using full faithfulness of $j_* \colon \mathsf{D}(U) \to \mathsf{D}(Y)$). Since K-theory sends Karoubi sequences to fiber sequences of spectra, the K-theory square is also a pullback.

1.1.5. Milnor excision

Restricting to affine schemes, Nisnevich squares take a particularly clean ring-theoretic form.

Definition 1.1.12 (Milnor square). A **Milnor square** for a commutative ring R is a pullback

$$\begin{tikzcd} R \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & R/I \arrow[d] \\ R_f \arrow[r] & R_f/IR_f \end{tikzcd}$$

where $f \in R$, $I \subset R$ is an ideal, and $R/I \xrightarrow{\sim} R_f/IR_f$ (equivalently, f is a unit in R/I).

A Milnor square is precisely a Nisnevich square for affine schemes: $U = \mathrm{Spec}(R_f) \hookrightarrow \mathrm{Spec}(R) = X$ is the principal open defined by f, and $V = \mathrm{Spec}(R/I) \to X$ is a closed immersion. The condition $R/I \simeq R_f/IR_f$ is exactly $p^{-1}(X \setminus U) \simeq X \setminus U$.

Proposition 1.1.13 (Milnor excision). *For every Nisnevich sheaf $\mathcal{F}$ and every Milnor square,*

$$\mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R)) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R_f)) \times_{\mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R_f/IR_f))} \mathcal{F}(\mathrm{Spec}(R/I)).$$

1.2. $\mathbb{A}^1$-Localization

Write $\mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ for the full subcategory of **$\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant** presheaves: those $\mathcal{F}$ with $\mathcal{F}(U) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}(U \times_S \mathbb{A}^1)$ for all $U \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$. The inclusion admits a left adjoint

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S),$$

called the **$\mathbb{A}^1$-localization functor**.

Definition 1.2.1 ($\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence and $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy). Let $f \colon \mathcal{F} \to \mathcal{G}$ be a morphism in $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$.

- f is an **$\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence** if $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(f)$ is an isomorphism.
- Two maps $f, g \colon \mathcal{F} \to \mathcal{G}$ are **$\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic** if there exists $H \colon \mathcal{F} \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathcal{G}$ with $H \circ i_0 \simeq f$ and $H \circ i_1 \simeq g$, where $i_s \colon * \to \mathbb{A}^1$ is the inclusion of $s \in \{0, 1\}$.
- f is an **$\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalence** if there exists g with fg and gf each $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to the appropriate identity.

Proposition 1.2.2. *Every $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalence is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence. In particular, the projection $p\colon \mathcal{F} \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathcal{F}$ is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalence for every $\mathcal{F}$.*

Proof. We first show $p\colon X \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to X$ is an $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalence for every $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ (and hence, by universal colimits in PShv, for every presheaf). The zero section $s\colon X \to X \times \mathbb{A}^1$ satisfies $p \circ s = \mathrm{id}_X$. The reverse composite $s \circ p$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to $\mathrm{id}_{X\times\mathbb{A}^1}$ via

$$(X \times \mathbb{A}^1) \times \mathbb{A}^1 \xrightarrow{\mathrm{id}_X \times \mu} X \times \mathbb{A}^1,$$

where $\mu\colon \mathbb{A}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathbb{A}^1$ is the ring multiplication: at $t = 1$ this gives $\mathrm{id}_{X\times\mathbb{A}^1}$, at $t = 0$ it gives $s \circ p$.

Now suppose $a, b\colon \mathcal{F} \to \mathcal{G}$ are $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic via H. Since $p \circ i_0 = p \circ i_1 = \mathrm{id}$ and $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(p)$ is an isomorphism, applying $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ gives $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_0) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_1)$. Hence

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(a) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(H) \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_0) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(H) \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(i_1) = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(b).$$

The result follows from the definition of homotopy equivalence. □

1.2.1. Interval objects

We have encountered three a priori distinct notions: $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization, localization at $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalences, and the $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$-construction via $\Delta^\bullet$. Do they coincide? Following Hoyois [Hoy], the answer is yes, and this is a formal consequence of $\mathbb{A}^1$ being an **interval object**.

Definition 1.2.3 (Bipointed object)**.** Let $\mathcal{C}$ be a category with finite products. A **bipointed object** is an object $I \in \mathcal{C}$ with two global sections $0, 1\colon * \rightrightarrows I$.

Definition 1.2.4 (Three homotopy categories)**.** Let $\mathcal{C}$ have finite products and I be a bipointed object.

(i) **I-localization** (nullification): formally invert all projections $X \times I \to X$:

$$\mathcal{C}/I \coloneqq \mathcal{C}\left[\{X \times I \to X\}^{-1}\right].$$

(ii) **Localization at I-homotopy equivalences**:

$$\mathcal{C}\left[\mathrm{hoeq}_I^{-1}\right].$$

(iii) **I-homotopy category**, via simplicial enrichment:

$$\mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C}, I), \qquad \mathrm{Map}_{\mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C},I)}(X, Y) = \mathrm{colim}_{\Delta^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathrm{Map}_{\mathcal{C}}(X \times I^n, Y).$$

In general, there are canonical functors

$$\mathcal{C}\left[\mathrm{hoeq}_I^{-1}\right] \longrightarrow \mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C}, I) \longrightarrow \mathcal{C}/I,$$

neither of which is generally an equivalence.

Definition 1.2.5 (Interval object)**.** A bipointed object $I \in \mathcal{C}$ is an **interval object** if

(i) $X \times I$ exists for all $X \in \mathcal{C}$;

(ii) I is I-contractible: $I \to *$ is an I-homotopy equivalence.

Example 1.2.6.

- The unit interval $[0, 1] \in \mathsf{Top}$ with multiplication $\mu(x, y) = xy$.
- The affine line $\mathbb{A}^1 \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ with ring multiplication.
- The real line $\mathbb{R}$ and complex plane $\mathbb{C}$ in Top, both with multiplication.

Theorem 1.2.7 (Morel–Voevodsky [MV99])**.** *For any category $\mathcal{C}$ and interval object $I \in \mathcal{C}$,*

$$\mathcal{C}\left[\mathrm{hoeq}_I^{-1}\right] \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{Ho}(\mathcal{C}, I) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{C}/I.$$

Proof sketch. **Left equivalence.** I-contractibility provides a zigzag of I-homotopies connecting id_I to the constant map $0\colon I \to * \to I$. Taking products with X shows that $(\mathrm{id}_X, 0)\colon X \to X \times I$ is an I-homotopy inverse to pr_1, so every projection $X \times I \to X$ is an I-homotopy equivalence.

Right equivalence. The I-homotopy from id_I to 0 induces a simplicial homotopy between the corresponding endomorphisms of $\mathrm{Map}(I \times I^\bullet, Y)$. After $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}}$ this becomes an isomorphism, identifying mapping anima in $\mathrm{Ho}(C, I)$ with those in C/I. □

Corollary 1.2.8. *The affine line $\mathbb{A}^1$ with sections $0, 1$ and ring multiplication is an interval object in Sm_S and in $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$. Hence the three a priori distinct notions in §1.2 coincide on $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$:*

(i) $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization (inverting $\mathcal{F} \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathcal{F}$);

(ii) localization at $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy equivalences;

(iii) the singular complex $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$.

***Remark* 1.2.9.** The multiplication $\mu(x, y) = xy$ on $\mathbb{A}^1$ provides the $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy from $\mathrm{id}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ (at $y = 1$) to the constant map 0 (at $y = 0$). This is why 1, not 0, plays the role of the basepoint: the unit of the multiplication is the structure that makes $\mathbb{A}^1$ an interval object.

1.2.2. Explicit formula for $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$

Corollary 1.2.8 identifies $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization abstractly with the $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy category $\mathrm{Ho}(\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S), \mathbb{A}^1)$, whose mapping anima are given by $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathrm{Map}(- \times \mathbb{A}^\bullet, -)$. We now convert this into an explicit "singular complex" formula, modelled on its topological namesake.

The $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization functor admits an explicit formula via an algebraic singular complex.

Definition 1.2.10 (Algebraic simplex)**.** The standard n-simplex over S is

$$\Delta^n_S \;:=\; \mathrm{Spec}\big(\mathcal{O}_S[T_0, \dots, T_n]/(T_0 + \cdots + T_n - 1)\big) \;\subset\; \mathbb{A}^{n+1}_S.$$

Face and degeneracy maps are defined as in topology, yielding a cosimplicial scheme $\Delta^\bullet_S\colon \mathbf{\Delta} \to \mathsf{Sch}_S$. Note $\Delta^n_S \simeq \mathbb{A}^n_S$ as S-schemes (but not as cosimplicial objects).

Theorem 1.2.11 (Explicit formula for $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization)**.** *For $\mathcal{F} \in \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ and $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$,*

$$(\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}\mathcal{F})(X) \;\simeq\; \mathrm{colim}_{[n]\in\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^n_S).$$

Proof. Write $\mathcal{F}'(X) := \mathrm{colim}_{[n]\in\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^n_S)$.

$\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. The projection $p\colon X \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to X$ and zero section s induce maps on the cosimplicial objects $X \times \Delta^\bullet_S$ and $X \times \mathbb{A}^1 \times \Delta^\bullet_S$. We have $s^* \circ p^* = \mathrm{id}$, and the multiplication $\mu\colon \mathbb{A}^1 \times \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathbb{A}^1$ defines an $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy $p^*s^* \simeq \mathrm{id}$. Since $\Delta^1_S \simeq \mathbb{A}^1_S$, this $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopy translates into a simplicial homotopy on $\mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S)$ between p^*s^* and id, which becomes an equivalence after $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}}$. Hence $p^*\colon \mathcal{F}'(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}'(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$.

Universal property. Let $\mathcal{G}$ be $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant. Since $\Delta^n_S \simeq \mathbb{A}^n_S$, $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance forces $\mathcal{G}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S)$ to have all simplicial structure maps acting as equivalences; hence $\mathrm{colim}_{\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathcal{G}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S) \simeq \mathcal{G}(X)$. Therefore

$$\mathrm{Map}(\mathcal{F}', \mathcal{G}) \simeq \lim_{\mathbf{\Delta}} \mathrm{Map}(\mathcal{F}(- \times \Delta^n_S), \mathcal{G}) \simeq \mathrm{Map}\big(\mathcal{F}, \lim_{\mathbf{\Delta}} \mathcal{G}(- \times \Delta^n_S)\big) \simeq \mathrm{Map}(\mathcal{F}, \mathcal{G}).$$ □

***Remark* 1.2.12** (Geometric meaning)**.** Theorem 1.2.11 is the algebro-geometric analogue of the topological singular complex $\mathrm{Sing}_\bullet$. The simplicial anima $\mathcal{F}(X \times \Delta^\bullet_S)$ encodes algebraic homotopy information: 0-simplices are sections, 1-simplices parametrize $\mathbb{A}^1$-paths, 2-simplices parametrize higher homotopies. Taking the colimit over $\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}$ quotients out all $\mathbb{A}^1$-deformations.

Caveat: $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ does not generally preserve Nisnevich sheaves, so the motivic localization $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$ is *not* simply $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$; see Remark 1.3.3.

1.3. Motivic Spaces

We now assemble the construction. Let S be qcqs. Since Sm_S is extensive, $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}_\sqcup(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$, and finite coproduct decompositions are Nisnevich covers, so $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \subset \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$.

Definition 1.3.1 (Motivic spaces). The category of **motivic spaces** over S is

$$\mathsf{H}(S) \;:=\; \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \cap \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \;\subset\; \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S),$$

consisting of presheaves of anima satisfying both Nisnevich descent and $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. The corresponding localization functor is

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{H}(S).$$

A morphism in $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ is a **motivic equivalence** if $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$ sends it to an equivalence.

Fact 1.3.2. *(i) $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$ is left exact. Both $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ and $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$ preserve finite products [Hoy14, Proposition C.6].*

(ii) Motivic equivalences form the smallest strongly saturated class in $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ containing both Nisnevich-local and $\mathbb{A}^1$-local equivalences.

***Remark* 1.3.3** (Non-commutativity of localizations). In general, neither $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} = \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$ nor $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} = \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ holds: $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ can destroy Nisnevich descent, while $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$ can destroy $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. Nevertheless, $\mathsf{H}(S)$ is defined as an intersection, and is therefore independent of the order of localization. Concretely, the motivic localization is computed by ping-ponging:

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}} \;\simeq\; (\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1})^{\circ \mathbb{N}},$$

i.e., by alternating the two localizations transfinitely until the process stabilizes.

In the spectra-valued setting, however, $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ preserves Nisnevich descent, since Sp is stable (then cartesian in Proposition 1.1.7 is also cocartesian); that is, one obtains a functor

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{Nis}} \colon \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \to \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}).$$

1.3.1. Motivic spaces and K-theory

Connective K-theory $\mathrm{k} \colon \mathsf{Sm}_S^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{An}$ satisfies Nisnevich descent (Example 1.1.11) and is $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant when the base is regular, hence defines an object of $\mathsf{H}(S)$.

Theorem 1.3.4 (Representability of K-theory). *For S regular Noetherian of finite Krull dimension,*

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}(\mathbb{Z} \times \mathrm{BGL}_\infty) \;\simeq\; \mathrm{k}.$$

In particular, for affine $U \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$, $[U, \mathbb{Z} \times \mathrm{BGL}_\infty]_{\mathsf{H}(S)} \simeq \mathrm{K}_0(U)$.

***Remark* 1.3.5** (Affine representability). Although Vect_r is not $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant on all smooth schemes (Remark 1.0.1), motivic localization still yields the correct values on smooth affine schemes: Asok–Hoyois–Wendt [AHW17] proved that if X is a presheaf on Sm_S such that $\pi_0(X)$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant on affine schemes and X satisfies affine Nisnevich excision, then $\pi_0(X)(U) \xrightarrow{\sim} [U, X]_{\mathsf{H}(S)}$ for all smooth affine U. Taking $X = \mathrm{BGL}_r$ gives $\pi_0\mathsf{Vect}_r(U) \simeq [U, \mathrm{BGL}_r]_{\mathsf{H}(S)}$ for affine U.

***Remark* 1.3.6** (The role of regularity). Nisnevich descent of K-theory holds without regularity (Example 1.1.11); $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance does not. For regular Noetherian X, Quillen proved $\mathrm{K}_n(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{K}_n(X \times \mathbb{A}^1)$ for all $n \geq 0$. For singular schemes this fails: with $R = k[\varepsilon]/(\varepsilon^2)$,

$$\mathrm{K}_1(R[t]) \neq \mathrm{K}_1(R),$$

since $(1 + \varepsilon t) \in R[t]^\times$ contributes a class in $\mathrm{K}_1(R[t])$ not coming from $\mathrm{K}_1(R)$.

To restore $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance on non-regular schemes, Weibel introduced **homotopy K-theory**

$$\mathrm{KH}(X) \;:=\; \mathrm{colim}_{[n] \in \mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}} \mathrm{K}\big(X \times \Delta^n\big),$$

which is precisely $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ applied to K.

1.4. Pointed Motivic Spaces

1.4.1. Basic constructions

Definition 1.4.1 (Pointed motivic spaces). The category $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ of **pointed motivic spaces** is the category of pointed objects in $\mathsf{H}(S)$.

The functor $(-)_+ : \mathsf{H}(S) \to \mathsf{H}_*(S)$ adds a disjoint basepoint, $X_+ = X \sqcup *$, and is left adjoint to the forgetful functor.

The **smash product** on $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ is the pushout

$$X \wedge Y \;:=\; \mathrm{cofib}(X \vee Y \to X \times Y),$$

making $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ symmetric monoidal with unit S_+.

We adopt the basepoint conventions:

- $\mathbb{A}^1$ is pointed at 1;
- $\mathbb{G}_m$ is pointed at 1;
- $\mathbb{P}^1$ is pointed at $\infty = [1 : 0]$.

Definition 1.4.2 (Suspension and loops). For $X \in \mathsf{H}_*(S)$,

- the **suspension** $\Sigma X := S^1 \wedge X$, where $S^1 = [1]/\partial[1]$ is the simplicial circle (as a constant sheaf);
- the **loop space** $\Omega X := \mathrm{fib}(* \to X)$.

These form an adjunction $\Sigma \dashv \Omega$.

1.4.2. Bigraded spheres

In $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ there are two essentially different "circles".

Definition 1.4.3 (Motivic spheres).

- The **simplicial circle** is $S^{1,0} := S^1$ (constant sheaf).
- The **Tate circle** is $S^{1,1} := \mathbb{G}_m$ (pointed at 1).
- The **motivic (p, q)-sphere**, for $p \geq q \geq 0$, is

$$S^{p,q} \;:=\; (S^{1,0})^{\wedge(p-q)} \wedge (S^{1,1})^{\wedge q}.$$

The key computation:

Proposition 1.4.4 ($\mathbb{P}^1$ as a motivic sphere). *In* $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$, $\mathbb{P}^1 \simeq S^{2,1} = S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$.

Proof. Consider the standard Nisnevich square for $\mathbb{P}^1$:

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[d] \\ \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[r] & \mathbb{P}^1. \end{tikzcd}$$

By Brown–Gersten in the pointed setting, this is a pushout square in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$. Since $\mathbb{A}^1 \simeq *$ in $\mathsf{H}(S)$, both copies of $\mathbb{A}^1$ collapse to the basepoint, and the pushout becomes

$$\mathbb{P}^1 \;\simeq\; * \sqcup_{\mathbb{G}_m} * \;\simeq\; \Sigma\mathbb{G}_m \;=\; S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m \;=\; S^{2,1}. \qquad \square$$

***Remark* 1.4.5.** This makes precise the observation that $\mathbb{G}_m$ realizes a kind of "algebraic circle": under Betti realization $\mathbb{G}_m(\mathbb{C}) = \mathbb{C}^\times$ is homotopy equivalent to the topological S^1. The motivic sphere $\mathbb{G}_m$ plays the role of $S^{1,1}$, while the simplicial circle S^1 is $S^{1,0}$. Their smash product $\mathbb{P}^1 \simeq S^{2,1}$ is the natural "algebraic 2-sphere".

This bigraded structure is what makes motivic homotopy theory richer than classical homotopy theory: the weight direction q encodes Tate twists specific to algebraic geometry.

Proposition 1.4.6 (Punctured affine spaces). *For $n \geq 1$, $\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \simeq S^{2n-1,n}$ in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ (with any choice of basepoint, e.g. $(1, 0, \ldots, 0)$).*

Proof. By induction on n. The case $n = 1$ is $\mathbb{A}^1 \setminus \{0\} = \mathbb{G}_m \simeq S^{1,1}$. For $n \geq 2$, the Nisnevich square

$$\begin{tikzcd} (\mathbb{A}^{n-1} \setminus \{0\}) \times \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{A}^{n-1} \times \mathbb{G}_m \arrow[d] \\ (\mathbb{A}^{n-1} \setminus \{0\}) \times \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[r] & \mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \end{tikzcd}$$

is a pushout in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$. Since $\mathbb{A}^1 \simeq *$, the right two terms collapse, yielding

$$\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \;\simeq\; \Sigma\big((\mathbb{A}^{n-1} \setminus \{0\}) \wedge \mathbb{G}_m\big) \;=\; S^{1,0} \wedge S^{2n-3,n-1} \wedge S^{1,1} \;=\; S^{2n-1,n}. \qquad \square$$

Corollary 1.4.7 (Thom spaces). *In $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$,*

$$\mathbb{A}^n/(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\}) \;\simeq\; S^{2n,n} \quad \textit{and} \quad \mathbb{P}^n/\mathbb{P}^{n-1} \;\simeq\; S^{2n,n}.$$

Proof. The cofiber sequence $\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\} \to \mathbb{A}^n \to \mathbb{A}^n/(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\})$ together with $\mathbb{A}^n \simeq *$ gives

$$\mathbb{A}^n/(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\}) \;\simeq\; \Sigma(\mathbb{A}^n \setminus \{0\}) \;\simeq\; \Sigma S^{2n-1,n} \;=\; S^{2n,n}.$$

For the second, use the standard open cover of $\mathbb{P}^n$ and induction. $\square$

Chapter 2.

Stable Motivic Homotopy Theory

The category $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ constructed in the previous chapter — pointed objects in $\mathsf{H}(S) = \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \cap \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ — is already rich enough to host a great deal of algebraic geometry. What it lacks is the formal machinery of a stable homotopy theory: fibre and cofibre sequences that coincide, the suspension–loop equivalence $\Sigma \simeq \Omega^{-1}$, and the six-functor formalism that underlies modern thinking about cohomology. All of these become available after one further universal step: formally inverting the Tate object $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$ under the smash product. The result is $\mathsf{SH}(S)$, the **motivic stable homotopy category**, the central object of this chapter.

The parallel with sheaf theory on a topological space offers a useful compass:

Sheaves on a space X		**Motivic world over S**
$\mathsf{Shv}(X, \mathsf{An})$	$\longleftrightarrow$	$\mathsf{H}(S)$
$\mathsf{Shv}(X, \mathsf{An}_*)$	$\longleftrightarrow$	$\mathsf{H}_*(S)$
$\mathsf{Shv}(X, \mathsf{Sp})$	$\longleftrightarrow$	$\mathsf{SH}(S)$

The correspondence is an abstract guide rather than a literal equivalence: on the motivic side one can also form $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ by starting from spectrum-valued presheaves on Sm_S and imposing the same two descent conditions, and $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ differs from this naive stabilisation precisely because we have inverted the Tate object rather than the simplicial circle alone. Working out the precise relationship between $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ is one of the main goals of this chapter.

Why single out this particular universal construction? Grothendieck envisioned, long before stable categories were available, that every cohomology theory on schemes should factor through a single universal "category of motives". In the modern dictionary "studying cohomology" is increasingly understood as "studying six-functor formalisms", and Grothendieck's programme becomes the search for a universal such formalism.

Drew–Gallauer [DG22] supplied a precise form of this search: there is a universal presentable six-functor formalism on finite-type schemes which is cohomologically smooth, satisfies excision, and kills the $\mathbb{A}^1$-homology. This universal object is the motivic formalism SH of Morel–Voevodsky. The span-category framework underlying this statement is set up in §2.2.1, and the theorem is stated precisely in §2.2.6.

Their proof is constructive and recovers the construction we shall give: the passage to $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_-, \mathsf{Sp})$ is forced by excision, and $\otimes$-inverting $\mathbb{T}_S$ is forced by the triviality of $\mathbb{A}^1$-homology.

It bears emphasising that SH is not the final word: the axioms above — especially $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance — exclude important arithmetic-geometric cohomology theories. Prismatic cohomology does not factor through SH, and more generally p-adic cohomology theories in characteristic p require fundamentally different frameworks. One should therefore think of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ as the universal coefficient system for $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology, not as the definitive answer to Grothendieck's question.

The chapter proceeds in five stages.

- §2.1 constructs $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ as the formal inversion of $\mathbb{T}_S$ in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$, developing the telescope and symmetric-spectrum models that the construction rests upon.
- §2.2 equips SH with its six-functor formalism via the span-category framework of Mann and Scholze, derives cdh descent as a consequence, and establishes the Drew–Gallauer universal property advertised above.

- §2.3 compares $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ with the naive stabilisation $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ via graded-algebra data and Bott-periodic modules. The resulting dictionary translates classical $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology theories into motivic ring spectra.
- §2.3.6 applies this dictionary in a central case, constructing the motivic K-theory spectrum KGL together with its base-change and cdh-descent properties.
- The remaining sections take up finer structural themes: orientation and formal group laws, the motivic filtration, and low-weight motivic cohomology.

2.1. Formal inversion

This section gives a careful construction of the stable motivic category $\mathsf{SH}(S)$, together with the technology—symmetric sequences, free algebras, Bousfield localization—needed both for this construction and for the construction of specific motivic spectra in subsequent sections.

Before entering the construction, let us briefly recall the setting established in Chapter 1. For a quasi-compact quasi-separated scheme S, we built $\mathsf{H}(S)$ as the full subcategory

$$\mathsf{H}(S) \;=\; \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \cap \mathsf{PShv}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \;\subset\; \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$$

of presheaves of anima satisfying both Nisnevich descent and $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance. The pointed variant $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ was obtained by passing to pointed objects, and we defined the Tate object

$$\mathbb{T}_S \;\coloneqq\; \mathrm{cofib}\big(\infty\colon S \hookrightarrow \mathbb{P}^1_S\big) \;\in\; \mathsf{H}_*(S),$$

which by Proposition 1.4.4 is equivalent to $S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m = S^{2,1}$.

The goal of this section is to invert $\mathbb{T}_S$ under the smash product, producing a presentably symmetric monoidal category $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ that extends the construction chain

$$\mathsf{Sm}_S \xrightarrow{y} \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \xrightarrow{\mathrm{L_{mot}}} \mathsf{H}(S) \xrightarrow{(-)_+} \mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{\sigma^\infty} \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

from Chapter 1 by one further universal step.

2.1.1. The universal $\otimes$-inversion problem

Let $\mathcal{C} \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$ be a presentably symmetric monoidal category and let $T \in \mathcal{C}$. We seek the initial presentably symmetric monoidal $\mathcal{C}$-algebra in which the image of T becomes $\otimes$-invertible: that is, the initial object of $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)_{\mathcal{C}/}$ whose structure functor sends T to an invertible object.

Definition 2.1.1. Let $\mathcal{C} \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$ and $\mathcal{D} \in \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$. Given a Bousfield localization $L\colon \mathcal{D} \to \mathcal{D}'$, we say L is **symmetric monoidal** if the composition $\mathcal{D} \xrightarrow{L} \mathcal{D}' \hookrightarrow \mathcal{D}$ is of the form $A\otimes -$ for some $A \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathcal{C})$.

***Remark* 2.1.2.** Symmetric monoidal localizations are also called **$\otimes$-Bousfield localizations** in some references, reflecting the fact that they are precisely the Bousfield localizations whose class of local equivalences is closed under $-\otimes X$ for every $X \in \mathcal{D}$.

Proposition 2.1.3 ([Rob15, Proposition 2.9],[Al25, 1.2.2])**.** *There exists a symmetric monoidal Bousfield localization*

$$(-)[T^{-1}]\colon \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L) \to \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L).$$

For a $\mathcal{C}$-module $\mathcal{D}$, we refer to $\mathcal{D}[T^{-1}]$ as the **formal inversion** of T in $\mathcal{D}$.

***Remark* 2.1.4.** Since the localization $(-)[T^{-1}]$ is symmetric monoidal, the unit map $u\colon \mathcal{C} \to \mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]$ exhibits $\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]$ as an idempotent in $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$, and thus u induces a symmetric monoidal structure on $\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]$, which in turn induces an equivalence

$$\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}[T^{-1}]}(\mathsf{Pr}^L) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{C}}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)[T^{-1}].$$

This motivates the following abstract definition.

Definition 2.1.5. The **motivic stable homotopy category** is the formal inversion of $\mathbb{T}_S$ in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$:

$$\mathsf{SH}(S) \;:=\; \mathsf{H}_*(S)\big[\mathbb{T}_S^{-1}\big].$$

This definition is, however, too abstract to have geometric intuition; we need a concrete model of the localization $(-)[\mathbb{T}_S^{-1}]$.

$$\begin{tikzcd}
 & C[T^{-1}] \arrow[d, "\simeq"] \\
C \arrow[ur, "\text{formal inversion}"] \arrow[r, "\mathbb{F}"] \arrow[dr, "\mathbb{N}"'] & \mathsf{Sp}_T(C) \arrow[d, "\simeq \text{when } T \text{ is symmetric}"] \\
 & \mathsf{Tel}_T(C)
\end{tikzcd}$$

Here $\mathbb{F}$ refers to the free model via symmetric sequences (§ 2.1.3), and $\mathbb{N}$ refers to the telescope construction; the two agree when T is symmetric, see Proposition 2.1.16.

2.1.2. Symmetric sequences and free algebras

Definition 2.1.6 (Symmetric sequences)**.** Let $\mathbb{F} = \mathsf{Fin}^{\simeq}$ denote the groupoid of finite sets and bijections. For $C \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$, the category of **symmetric sequences** in C is

$$\mathsf{SSeq}(C) := \mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{F}, C),$$

equipped with the Day convolution symmetric monoidal structure induced by the disjoint-union monoidal structure on $\mathbb{F}$.

In fact, an object in $\mathsf{SSeq}(C)$ is given by a sequence $E_\bullet = (E_0, E_1, \ldots)$ in C with a Σ_n-action on E_n. For $X_\bullet, Y_\bullet \in \mathsf{SSeq}(C)$, we have a formula

$$(X_\bullet \otimes Y_\bullet)_n = \bigoplus_{p+q=n} \Sigma_{p+q} \otimes_{\Sigma_p \times \Sigma_q} (X_p \otimes Y_q).$$

From this perspective, one obtains several canonical functors:

- $U\colon \mathsf{SSeq}(C) \to C$, carrying $X_\bullet$ to X_0.
- $F\colon C \to \mathsf{SSeq}(C)$, carrying C to $(C, \varnothing, \varnothing, \ldots)$, and left adjoint to U.
- A shift functor $s_-\colon \mathsf{SSeq}(C) \to \mathsf{SSeq}(C)$, given by

$$(s_- Y)_\bullet := (Y_1, Y_2, \ldots).$$

- s_- admits a left adjoint s_+, given by

$$(s_+ Y)_\bullet := \big(\varnothing,\, Y_0,\, \ldots,\, \Sigma_n \otimes_{\Sigma_{n-1}} Y_{n-1},\, \ldots\big).$$

***Remark* 2.1.7** (Notation)**.** The notation s_+ (left adjoint, "shift up") and s_- (right adjoint, "shift down") is borrowed from [AI25, 1.3.1]. We will see in Lemma 2.1.12 that, after passing to $\mathsf{Sp}_T(C)$, the localized s_- becomes equivalent to $T \otimes -$ and s_+ becomes equivalent to $\mathrm{Map}(T, -)$. Despite this, we will retain the traditional notation σ^∞ and ω^∞ for the resulting suspension spectrum / underlying object adjunction, in line with the analogy with classical spectra; see the discussion after Definition 2.1.11.

Definition 2.1.8 (Symmetric algebra)**.** For $X \in C$, write

$$\mathrm{Sym}(X) \;:=\; \bigoplus_{n \geq 0} \big(X^{\otimes n}\big)_{h\Sigma_n} \;\in\; \mathsf{CAlg}(C)$$

for the symmetric algebra generated by X.

2.1.3. Lax T-spectra, T-spectra, and T-telescopes

For $T \in \mathcal{C}$, consider the symmetric sequence

$$T_{\mathrm{sym}} := s_+F(T) = (\varnothing, T, \varnothing, \varnothing, \ldots) \in \mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C}).$$

We may form its symmetric algebra $\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C}))$.

Definition 2.1.9 (Lax T-spectra). The category of **lax T-spectra** in $\mathcal{C}$ is

$$\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C}) := \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}})}(\mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C})) \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)_{\mathcal{C}/}.$$

The adjunction (F, U), together with the free-module functor $\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) \otimes -$, induces an adjunction

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathcal{C} \arrow[r, shift left, "F_T"] \arrow[r, phantom, "\perp"] & \mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C}) \arrow[l, shift left, "U"] \end{tikzcd}$$

We may therefore use U to study the structure of $\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C})$.

Lemma 2.1.10. *For each $n \geq 0$, $U_n(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) \simeq T^{\otimes n}$.*

Proof. Note that we have

$$U_n(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) = U_n(\mathrm{Sym}^n(s_+F(T))) \simeq (\Sigma_n \otimes T^{\otimes n})_{h\Sigma_n}.$$

Here the Σ_n-action on $\Sigma_n \otimes T^{\otimes n}$ is the diagonal action and thus the homotopy orbit is equivalent to $T^{\otimes n}$. □

This lemma shows that lax T-spectra "see" $T^{\otimes n}$ at level n; consequently, by Bousfield localizing at the relevant bonding maps, we will obtain a concrete model of T-spectra from $\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C})$.

Definition 2.1.11 (T-spectra). The category of **T-spectra** in $\mathcal{C}$ is the accessible localization

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathsf{Sp}} \colon \mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C}) \to \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C}),$$

spanned by lax T-spectra E for which the structure map $E \to (s_-E)^T$ is an equivalence.

More concretely, an object of $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$ is a sequence $E_\bullet = (E_0, E_1, \ldots)$ in $\mathcal{C}$ with Σ_n-action on E_n, together with bonding equivalences

$$E_n \xrightarrow{\sim} \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(T, E_{n+1}) \qquad (n \geq 0).$$

By [Lur17, Proposition 4.1.7.4], $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$ admits a unique presentably symmetric monoidal structure for which L_{Sp} is symmetric monoidal.

Lemma 2.1.12 ([Al25, 1.3.13]). *On $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$, there are natural equivalences*

$$s_- \simeq T \otimes -, \qquad \mathrm{L}_{\mathsf{Sp}}\, s_+ \simeq \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(T, -),$$

and T acts as an equivalence on $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$. In particular, $\mathrm{L}_{\mathsf{Sp}}\, s_+$ and s_- are mutually inverse equivalences of $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$.

The adjunction $F_T \dashv U$ can be derived to the following adjunction:

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathcal{C} \arrow[r, shift left, "\sigma^\infty"] \arrow[r, phantom, "\perp"] & \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C}) \arrow[l, shift left, "\omega^\infty"] \end{tikzcd}$$

where $\omega^\infty E = E_0$ on the underlying symmetric sequence. The notation is consistent with the analogy with classical spectra: σ^∞ sends an object of $\mathcal{C}$ to its T-suspension spectrum, while ω^∞ extracts the underlying 0-th level. Since T becomes invertible in $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$, this adjunction extends naturally: for each $n \in \mathbb{Z}$ one has an adjunction $\sigma^{\infty-n} \dashv \omega^{\infty-n}$, with $\omega^{\infty-n}E$ the "n-th level" of the spectrum.

Corollary 2.1.13 (Explicit description of T-spectra). *The data of an object $E \in \mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$ is equivalent to:*

- *a sequence of objects $\big(E(j)\big)_{j\in\mathbb{Z}}$ in $\mathcal{C}$, with $E(j) := \omega^{\infty-j}E$;*

- *equivalences* $E(j) \xrightarrow{\sim} \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(T, E(j+1))$ *for every* $j \in \mathbb{Z}$.

A commutative algebra structure on E *corresponds further to compatible graded multiplications* $E(i) \otimes E(j) \to E(i+j)$.

Proof. The first two clauses follow from Lemma 2.1.12; the multiplicative statement is dealt with in §2.3.1. □

Proposition 2.1.14 (Formal inversion and T-spectra, [Al25, 1.3.14]). *There is a categorical equivalence*

$$C[T^{-1}] \simeq \mathsf{Sp}_T(C).$$

Recall that in stable homotopy theory, stabilization is realized as a colimit. We now apply the same idea to give a more direct construction of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$: namely, by writing $C[T^{-1}]$ as a colimit along $T \otimes -$ in $\mathsf{Mod}_C(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$. This construction, however, requires an additional symmetry condition on T; see Proposition 2.1.16.

Definition 2.1.15. The category of T**-telescopes** in C is given by the following colimit in $\mathsf{Mod}_C(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$:

$$\mathsf{Tel}_T(C) := \operatorname{colim}\left(C \xrightarrow{T\otimes -} C \xrightarrow{T\otimes -} \cdots\right).$$

Proposition 2.1.16 (Telescope comparison, [Al25, 1.6.3]). *If* T *is* ***symmetric*** *in the sense that the cyclic permutation*

$$T^{\otimes 3} \longrightarrow T^{\otimes 3}, \qquad a \otimes b \otimes c \longmapsto b \otimes c \otimes a,$$

is homotopic to the identity in C*, then there is an equivalence*

$$C[T^{-1}] \simeq \mathsf{Sp}_T(C) \simeq \mathsf{Tel}_T(C)$$

in $\mathsf{Mod}_C(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$.

2.1.4. Specialization to motivic homotopy theory

We now apply the preceding machinery to motivic homotopy theory. The input is the pointed motivic homotopy category $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$ from Chapter 1, equipped with the smash product, and the Tate object $\mathbb{T}_S$.

Proposition 2.1.17 ($\mathbb{T}_S$ is symmetric). *The cyclic permutation* $\sigma\colon \mathbb{T}_S^{\wedge 3} \to \mathbb{T}_S^{\wedge 3}$ *is* $\mathbb{A}^1$*-homotopic to the identity in* $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$.

Proof. By Proposition 1.4.4, $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq \mathbb{P}^1_S$. It suffices to show that a transposition on $\mathbb{P}^1 \wedge \mathbb{P}^1$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to $-\mathrm{id}$, since a 3-cycle in Σ_3 is a composite of two transpositions and acts as $(-\mathrm{id})^2 = \mathrm{id}$.

Consider the action of $\mathrm{SL}_2(\mathbb{Z})$ on $\mathbb{P}^1 \wedge \mathbb{P}^1$ via its action on the two factors. Set

$$A := \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ -1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix}\begin{bmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Then $A \in \mathrm{SL}_2(\mathbb{Z})$ factors as a product of elementary matrices, and elementary matrices are $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to the identity via $\begin{bmatrix} 1 & t \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$, $t \in \mathbb{A}^1$. Therefore A is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to the identity, which gives

$$\begin{bmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \simeq \begin{bmatrix} -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Hence the transposition τ on $\mathbb{P}^1 \wedge \mathbb{P}^1$ is $\mathbb{A}^1$-homotopic to $(-\mathrm{id}) \wedge \mathrm{id} = -\mathrm{id}$. □

Corollary 2.1.18 (Telescope model of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$). *Applying Proposition 2.1.16 to* $(\mathsf{H}_*(S), \mathbb{T}_S)$ *yields*

$$\mathsf{SH}(S) \simeq \operatorname{colim}\left(\mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{-\wedge \mathbb{T}_S} \mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{-\wedge \mathbb{T}_S} \cdots\right)$$

in $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathsf{H}_*(S)}(\mathsf{Pr}^L)$.

Terminology 2.1.19. Objects of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ are called **($\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant) motivic spectra**.

Proposition 2.1.20 (Functoriality of SH). *The assignments $S \mapsto \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $(f : T \to S) \mapsto (f^* \colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \to \mathsf{SH}(T))$, where f^* is the symmetric monoidal pullback, define a functor*

$$\mathsf{SH} \colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \longrightarrow \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}).$$

Stability follows from $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$: inverting $\mathbb{T}_S$ inverts the simplicial S^1, hence $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is stable.

Putting together all the constructions from Chapter 1 and this section, the motivic spectrum functor $M_S \colon \mathsf{Sm}_S \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ factors as the composite

$$\mathsf{Sm}_S \xrightarrow{y} \mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_S) \xrightarrow{\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}} \mathsf{H}(S) \xrightarrow{(-)_+} \mathsf{H}_*(S) \xrightarrow{\sigma^\infty} \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

where each step realizes a universal property:

- y: free cocompletion;
- $\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}$: free imposition of Nisnevich descent and $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariance;
- $(-)_+$: free adjunction of a basepoint;
- σ^∞: free $\otimes$-inversion of $\mathbb{T}_S$ (Definition 2.1.5).

Concretely, $M_S(X) = \sigma^\infty\big(\mathrm{L}_{\mathrm{mot}}(X)_+\big)$ for $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$.

***Remark* 2.1.21.** Since every step can be upgraded to a symmetric monoidal functor, we have $M_S(S) \simeq \mathbf{1}_S \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $M_S(X \times_S Y) \simeq M_S(X) \otimes M_S(Y)$.

One also has the following properties:

- the map $M_S(\mathbb{A}^1) \to M_S(S)$ induced by $\mathbb{A}^1 \to S$ is an equivalence;
- the Tate motive $\mathbb{T}_S$ is the cofiber of $M_S(S) \xrightarrow{\infty^*} M_S(\mathbb{P}^1_S)$, and is invertible by construction;
- M_S carries Nisnevich distinguished squares in Sm_S to cartesian squares in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$.

From the construction above, $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is the initial presentably symmetric monoidal stable category satisfying the properties above.

Recall from Definition 1.4.3 that there are two types of "circles" in $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$. After stabilization, the simplicial circle corresponds to the suspension, namely to the pushout

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\ulcorner"] & 0 \arrow[d] \\ 0 \arrow[r] & E[1]. \end{tikzcd}$$

Combined with $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq S^1 \wedge \mathbb{G}_m$, the (i,j)-bigraded sphere can therefore be reformulated as

$$S^{i,j} \;\simeq\; \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}[i-2j].$$

Also, the suspension functor should be bigraded, that is for $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$, $\Sigma^{i,j}E$ should be $E \otimes S^{i,j}$.

It is useful to know that motivic spectra are determined by their pullbacks to fields, via the following proposition.

Proposition 2.1.22 ([BH21, B.3]). *Let S be a qcqs scheme locally of finite Krull dimension, and let $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$. Then $E = 0$ if and only if, for every point $x \in S$, the pullback $i_x^* E \in \mathsf{SH}(k(x))$ vanishes.*

One can also consider the stabilization of $\mathsf{H}_*(S)$, namely

$$\mathsf{Sp}(\mathsf{H}_*(S)) \;=\; \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}).$$

Since $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is a stable category, the functor σ^∞ extends to a symmetric monoidal functor

$$\sigma^\infty \colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \longrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

and its right adjoint ω^∞ extends to a lax symmetric monoidal functor

$$\omega^\infty \colon \mathsf{SH}(S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}),$$

which can be explicitly described as $\omega^\infty(E) = \mathrm{map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(M_S(-), E)$.

In fact, $\mathsf{SH}(S) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})[\mathbb{G}_m^{-1}]$ ([ABH26, 2.2.3]).

***Remark* 2.1.23.** Objects in $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ are also known as **motivic S^1-spectra**, and this category is sometimes denoted $\mathsf{SH}^{S^1}(S)$; we will not use this alternative notation.

2.2. The Six-Functor Formalism on SH

Having constructed SH as a functor $(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}})$, we now extend it to a full six-functor formalism. The modern way to package such a formalism is through span categories, so we begin by recording that framework in §2.2.1. The remaining subsections then apply it to SH: we introduce the cdh topology (§2.2.2), verify the localization axiom and base-change properties (§2.2.3), assemble the six-functor formalism for SH (§2.2.4), deduce cdh descent as a corollary (§2.2.5), and finally revisit the universal property of SH in its precise Drew–Gallauer form (§2.2.6).

2.2.1. Span categories and suitable decompositions

Classically, a six-functor formalism on a category C of geometric objects is a packet of data $(f^*, f_*, f_!, f^!, \otimes, \underline{\mathrm{Map}})$ subject to an intricate web of adjunctions, base change isomorphisms, and projection formula. Even writing down this data in a fully coherent categorical sense is a non-trivial task.

A far more economical description was initiated by Liu–Zheng [LZ24] and Gaitsgory–Rozenblyum [**?**], and brought to its present form by Mann [Man22] and Scholze [Sch26]. Given a wide subcategory $E \subset C$ closed under composition and base change, one forms the **span category** $\mathsf{Span}(C, E)$: its objects are those of C, and its morphisms $X \to Y$ are spans

$$X \longleftarrow Z \xrightarrow{e} Y, \qquad e \in E,$$

composed by pullback. When C has finite products, $\mathsf{Span}(C, E)$ inherits a symmetric monoidal structure. In this language, a **three-functor formalism** on (C, E) is simply a lax symmetric monoidal functor

$$\mathsf{D} \colon \mathsf{Span}(C, E) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Cat},$$

which encodes f^* (backward legs), $f_!$ (forward legs), and $\otimes$ (monoidal structure) in a single coherent package. The remaining three operations $f_*, f^!, \underline{\mathrm{Map}}$ are then obtained as right adjoints, and are therefore *properties* of D rather than additional structure.

The challenge is that constructing a lax monoidal functor out of $\mathsf{Span}(C, E)$ directly is hard. In practice, one starts from a much simpler piece of data, namely a functor

$$\mathsf{D}_0 \colon C^{\mathrm{op}} \longrightarrow \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Cat})$$

encoding only f^* and $\otimes$, and asks when it extends to $\mathsf{Span}(C, E)$. The key input is a **suitable decomposition** of E in the sense of Mann [Man22, Def. A.5.9]: a pair of wide subcategories $I, P \subset E$ (thought of as "open/étale-like" and "proper-like" morphisms respectively) such that every $e \in E$ factors as $e = p \circ i$ with $i \in I$ and $p \in P$, subject to mild cancellation and truncation axioms. The extension theorem then reads: if $i^* = \mathsf{D}_0(i)$ admits a left adjoint $i_\sharp$ and $p^* = \mathsf{D}_0(p)$ admits a right adjoint p_* satisfying the expected base change and projection formulae—crucially including the mixed Beck–Chevalley equivalence $i_\sharp p'_* \simeq p_* i'_\sharp$—then D_0 admits an essentially unique extension to a three-functor formalism D, in which

$$f_! = p_* \, i_\sharp \qquad \text{for any factorization } f = p \circ i.$$

Recently, Cnossen–Lenz–Linskens [CLL25] gave a conceptually streamlined account of this extension theorem: they construct a 2-categorical enhancement $\mathsf{Span}_2(\mathcal{C}, E)_{P,I}$ of $\mathsf{Span}(\mathcal{C}, E)$—whose 2-morphisms are spans of spans with legs in P and I—and show that the inclusion $\mathcal{C}^{\mathrm{op}} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{Span}_2(\mathcal{C}, E)_{P,I}$ is the universal (I, P)-biadjointable functor. Mann's result becomes a formal corollary, and as a byproduct one obtains 2-categorical coherence data for D — most notably, the unit and counit witnessing the adjunction $i_\sharp \dashv i^*$ become part of the structure of D, rather than non-canonical choices recoverable only after the fact. The adjoint functor $i_\sharp$ itself is, of course, already encoded in any ordinary six-functor formalism (as is the adjunction $p^* \dashv p_*$, both as functors and as adjunction data); what is genuinely new in the 2-categorical setup is the coherent specification of the $i_\sharp \dashv i^*$ adjunction data.

This is the framework in which we place SH. Taking $\mathcal{C} = \mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$, E = morphisms locally of finite presentation, I = étale morphisms, and P = proper morphisms, the six-functor formalism on SH will be obtained by verifying that $f^*\colon \mathsf{SH}(X) \to \mathsf{SH}(Y)$ and the smash product satisfy precisely the hypotheses above. The deep input—smooth base change and proper base change for SH—is classical work of Morel–Voevodsky [MV99] and Ayoub [Ayo07] / Cisinski–Déglise [CD19]; the verification is carried out in §2.2.3–§2.2.4 below, and the extension to the full six-functor package is then formal.

2.2.2. The cdh topology

In both Nisnevich and étale topologies, covering morphisms are étale, hence local homeomorphisms in the algebraic sense: they preserve dimension and tangent spaces. Consequently, *étale covers cannot resolve singularities*.

Recall the nodal curve $N = \mathrm{Spec}(k[x, y]/(y^2 - x^3 - x^2))$. The normalization $\varphi\colon \tilde{N} \to N$ is an isomorphism away from the origin but collapses two points to one at the origin—and is certainly not étale. To unify the study of singular and smooth schemes, we need a finer topology that treats blowups (and more generally, proper birational morphisms) as covers. This is the **cdh topology** (complete decomposition with h-descent).

Abstract blowup squares

Definition 2.2.1 (Abstract blowup square). A commutative diagram in Sch_S

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r] \arrow[d, "q"'] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & \tilde{X} \arrow[d, "p"] \\ Z \arrow[r, hook, "i"'] & X \end{tikzcd}$$

is an **abstract blowup square** if

- i is a closed immersion;
- p is proper;
- p induces an isomorphism $p^{-1}(X \setminus Z)_{\mathrm{red}} \xrightarrow{\sim} (X \setminus Z)_{\mathrm{red}}$;
- $E = \tilde{X} \times_X Z$ (as a reduced scheme).

***Remark* 2.2.2** (Comparison with Nisnevich squares). Abstract blowup squares are structurally parallel to Nisnevich squares:

	Nisnevich square	**Abstract blowup square**
Decomposition of X	$U \overset{\text{open}}{\hookrightarrow} X$	$Z \overset{\text{closed}}{\hookrightarrow} X$
Covering morphism	$V \to X$ étale	$\tilde{X} \to X$ proper
Isomorphism away from	$X \setminus U$	$X \setminus Z$
Typical source	Étale neighborhoods	Blowups, normalizations

Both decompose X into a known part and a part needing coverage, then handle the latter via the appropriate class of morphisms.

Example 2.2.3 (cdh cover of the nodal curve). For the nodal curve N with $\mathrm{char}(k) \neq 2$:

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & \tilde{N} \simeq \mathbb{A}^1 \arrow[d, "p"] \\ Z = \{0\} \arrow[r, hook] & N, \end{tikzcd}$$

where p is the normalization (finite, hence proper) and $E = \mathrm{Spec}(k[c]/(c^2 - 1)) \simeq \mathrm{Spec}(k) \sqcup \mathrm{Spec}(k)$ encodes the two tangent directions at the node. For a cdh sheaf $\mathcal{F}$,

$$\mathcal{F}(N) \simeq \mathcal{F}(\mathbb{A}^1) \times_{\mathcal{F}(\{c=1\} \sqcup \{c=-1\})} \mathcal{F}(\{0\}).$$

Thus invariants of the singular curve N are completely determined by their values on the smooth model $\mathbb{A}^1$, the singular point $\{0\}$, and the gluing data over E.

Definition of the cdh topology

Definition 2.2.4 (cdh topology). For X qcqs, the **cdh topology** on $\mathsf{Sch}_X^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$ is the Grothendieck topology generated by

(i) Nisnevich squares (Definition 1.1.5), and

(ii) abstract blowup squares (Definition 2.2.1).

A presheaf $\mathcal{F}$ on $\mathsf{Sch}_X^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$ is a **cdh sheaf** if it sends both types of squares to pullback squares—equivalently, satisfies both Nisnevich excision and proper excision.

Cohomological dimension of the Nisnevich and cdh topoi

A foundational structural result about the Nisnevich topology is a sharp bound on the homotopy dimension of its associated topos. Recall that a topos $\mathcal{X}$ has **homotopy dimension** $\leq d$ if every $(d-1)$-connected sheaf on $\mathcal{X}$ admits a global section. Equivalently, sheaves of n-truncated anima "can be controlled" once $n \geq d$.

Theorem 2.2.5 (Clausen–Mathew). *For any qcqs scheme X of finite Krull dimension,*

$$\dim \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Et}_X) \leq \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X),$$

where the left-hand side denotes the homotopy dimension of the Nisnevich topos on the small étale site of X, and $\mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$ is the Krull dimension.

***Remark* 2.2.6** (Geometric characterization of Nisnevich-local schemes). A qcqs scheme X has no nontrivial Nisnevich coverings if and only if X is henselian local. This explains why Nisnevich stalks are computed at henselian local rings: the strict henselization $\mathcal{O}^h_{X,x}$ at a point $x \in X$ realizes the Nisnevich-local model of an étale neighborhood of x. Combined with Theorem 2.2.5, this gives a tight geometric grip on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}$: sheaves are determined by their values on henselian local rings, and the Postnikov tower converges in finite Krull dimension.

This is a far-reaching generalization of the classical fact, due to Grothendieck and Kato–Saito, that Nisnevich cohomology vanishes above the Krull dimension. The categorical reformulation given by Clausen–Mathew is more powerful: it controls not only cohomology groups but also the truncation behavior of arbitrary sheaves of anima. In particular, on a finite-dimensional scheme, every Nisnevich sheaf of spectra is hypercomplete, and every Postnikov tower converges.

***Remark* 2.2.7** (Comparison with étale and Zariski). The bound in Theorem 2.2.5 is sharp and reflects another structural advantage of the Nisnevich topology over its neighbors:

- **Zariski:** $\dim \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Zar}}(X) \leq \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$ as well, but the Zariski topology is too coarse for many cohomology theories (e.g., it does not see Galois descent).

- **Étale:** no such finite bound holds in general; the étale topos can have infinite cohomological dimension (e.g., for $\mathrm{Spec}(k)$ with k a field of positive characteristic and large absolute Galois group).

The Nisnevich topology thus combines the dimensional finiteness of Zariski with enough geometric refinement to support algebraic K-theory and motivic constructions.

Just as the Nisnevich topos has homotopy dimension bounded by the Krull dimension (Theorem 2.2.5), the cdh topos admits a parallel bound, this time in terms of the valuation dimension. Recall:

Definition 2.2.8 (Valuation dimension)**.** The **valuation dimension** $\mathrm{v.dim}(X)$ of a qcqs scheme X is defined by $\mathrm{v.dim}(X) \leq d$ if and only if for every integral affine subscheme $\mathrm{Spec}(A) \subseteq X$ and every chain

$$A \subseteq V_0 \subseteq V_1 \subseteq \cdots \subseteq V_n \subseteq \mathrm{Frac}(A)$$

of valuation subrings of the fraction field with strict inclusions, one has $n \leq d$.

The valuation dimension always satisfies $\mathrm{v.dim}(X) \geq \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$, with equality when X is Noetherian or, more generally, when X is a valuative Noetherian scheme. The two notions coincide on most schemes one encounters in practice.

Theorem 2.2.9 (Elmanto–Hoyois–Iwasa–Kelly)**.** *For any qcqs scheme X,*

$$\dim \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{cdh}}(\mathsf{Sch}_X^{\mathrm{fp}}) \;\leq\; \mathrm{v.dim}(X),$$

where the left-hand side is the homotopy dimension of the cdh topos on the category of finitely presented X-schemes.

***Remark* 2.2.10** (Geometric characterization of cdh-local schemes)**.** Parallel to the Nisnevich case (Remark 2.2.6): a qcqs scheme X has no non-trivial cdh coverings if and only if every valuation ring of the function fields of X is henselian (one says X is *valuatively henselian* or that X is a *henselian valuation scheme*). Cdh stalks are accordingly computed at henselian valuation rings, and the dimensional bound of Theorem 2.2.9 measures the depth of these stalks via the valuation chain length.

***Remark* 2.2.11** (Why valuation dimension?)**.** The cdh topology is sensitive to phenomena invisible to the Nisnevich topology—namely, those involving non-Noetherian behavior such as the structure of valuation rings of fraction fields. The valuation dimension captures exactly the right invariant. Two key consequences:

(i) **$\mathbb{A}^1$-stability:** $\mathrm{v.dim}(X \times \mathbb{A}^n) = \mathrm{v.dim}(X) + n$, mirroring the analogous Krull dimension formula but more robustly behaved on non-Noetherian schemes.

(ii) **Coincidence with Krull dimension:** $\mathrm{v.dim}(X) = \mathrm{Kr.dim}(X)$ when X is Noetherian, or more generally a valuation ring.

On Noetherian schemes, Theorem 2.2.9 thus specializes to a Krull-dimensional bound, paralleling the Clausen–Mathew result for the Nisnevich topos. The genuinely new content is the extension to non-Noetherian schemes via valuation theory.

***Remark* 2.2.12** (Significance for motivic cohomology)**.** The bound in Theorem 2.2.9 is the key technical input for many recent advances in motivic cohomology over singular and non-Noetherian bases, including the construction of motivic cohomology of arbitrary qcqs schemes by Elmanto–Morrow [EM23], and the comparison with prismatic cohomology in Bachmann–Elmanto–Morrow [BEM25]. Without dimensional finiteness, Postnikov towers in the cdh topos would not converge, and the cdh-local replacement of motivic invariants would be intractable.

***Remark* 2.2.13** (Finitarity)**.** The Nisnevich and cdh topologies are both *finitary*: every covering family may be refined to a finite subcover. This is essential for several compatibility results we will use:

- Nisnevich and cdh sheafification commute with filtered colimits.
- The topoi $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)$ and $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{cdh}}(\mathsf{Sch}_S^{\mathrm{fp}})$ are compactly generated, with compact generators given by the (sheafifications of) representables.
- Hypercompletion behaves well, and on finite-dimensional schemes coincides with the topos itself by Theorems 2.2.5 and 2.2.9.

2.2.3. Localization and base change

Definition 2.2.14 (Localization axiom). A functor $\mathsf{D}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}_{\mathrm{st}}$ satisfies the **localization axiom** if for every $X \in \mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$, every closed immersion $i\colon Z \hookrightarrow X$ with open complement $j\colon U \hookrightarrow X$, the diagram

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathsf{D}(Z) \arrow[r, "i_*"] & \mathsf{D}(X) \arrow[l, bend right, "i^*"'] \arrow[l, bend left, "i^!"] \arrow[r, "j^*"] & \mathsf{D}(U) \arrow[l, bend right, "j_!"'] \arrow[l, bend left, "j_*"] \end{tikzcd}$$

is a recollement. That is, (i^*, j^*) is conservative, and both i_* and j_* are fully faithful.

Definition 2.2.15 (Base change properties). Let $\mathsf{D}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}_{\mathrm{st}}$ be a functor.

- We say a morphism $g\colon C \to D$ satisfies **left base change** if for every pullback square

$$\begin{tikzcd} A \arrow[r, "k"] \arrow[d, "h"'] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & B \arrow[d, "f"] \\ C \arrow[r, "g"'] & D \end{tikzcd}$$

  the functor $k^*\colon \mathsf{D}(B) \to \mathsf{D}(A)$ admits a left adjoint $k_\sharp$, and the canonical morphism $k_\sharp h^* \to f^* g_\sharp$ is an isomorphism.

- We say a morphism $f\colon B \to D$ satisfies **right base change** if for every pullback square as above, the functor $h^*\colon \mathsf{D}(C) \to \mathsf{D}(A)$ admits a right adjoint h_*, and the canonical morphism $g^* f_* \to h_* k^*$ is an isomorphism.

Proposition 2.2.16. *Let* $\mathsf{D}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}_{\mathrm{st}}$ *satisfy the localization axiom.*

(i) If étale morphisms satisfy left base change, then D *satisfies Nisnevich descent.*

(ii) If finitely presented proper morphisms satisfy right base change, then D *satisfies abstract blowup descent.*

Proof. We treat the case of abstract blowup descent; the Nisnevich case is similar (and dual). Consider an abstract blowup square

$$\begin{tikzcd} E \arrow[r, "k"] \arrow[d, "q"'] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & \tilde{X} \arrow[d, "p"] \\ Z \arrow[r, hook, "i"'] & X. \end{tikzcd}$$

By assumption, p^* and q^* admit right adjoints p_* and q_*. We must show that the functor

$$(p^*, i^*)\colon \mathsf{D}(X) \longrightarrow \mathsf{D}(\tilde{X}) \times_{\mathsf{D}(E)} \mathsf{D}(Z)$$

is an equivalence. Its right adjoint G sends a pair (A, B) with common image $C \in \mathsf{D}(E)$ to the pullback

$$G(A, B) \;=\; p_*A \times_{(iq)_*C} i_*B.$$

Conservativity. By the localization axiom, (i^*, j^*) is conservative, where $j\colon U = X \setminus Z \hookrightarrow X$. Since p restricts to an isomorphism over U, we have $j^* \simeq h^*p^*$ (with $h\colon U \hookrightarrow \tilde{X}$ the open complement of k), so (p^*, i^*) is also conservative.

Counit is an equivalence. It remains to show that for every (A, B), the counit map $(p^*, i^*) \circ G(A, B) \to (A, B)$ is an equivalence. We verify each component.

The i^*-component. Since i is a closed immersion, i_* is fully faithful by the localization axiom, so $i^*i_* \simeq \mathrm{id}$. Combined with right base change for p along i (giving $i^*p_*A \simeq q_*k^*A \simeq q_*C$), the fiber product becomes

$$i^*(p_*A \times_{(iq)_*C} i_*B) \;\simeq\; q_*C \times_{q_*C} B \;\simeq\; B.$$

The p^*-component. We must show $p^*(p_*A \times_{(iq)_*C} i_*B) \xrightarrow{\sim} A$. Since (k^*, h^*) is conservative on $\mathsf{D}(\tilde{X})$ by the localization axiom, we check after each.

Applying k^*: by $k^*p^* = q^*i^*$ and the previous case,

$$k^*p^*(p_*A \times_{(iq)_*C} i_*B) \;\simeq\; q^*B \;\simeq\; C \;\simeq\; k^*A.$$

Applying h^*: since i_*B and $(iq)_*C$ are supported on Z, applying $j^* = h^*p^*$ kills them, leaving j^*p_*A. We must show $j^*p_*A \simeq h^*A$. Consider the diagram of fiber sequences from the localization axiom:

$$\begin{tikzcd}
i_*i^!p_*A \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & p_*A \arrow[r] \arrow[d, equal] & j_*j^*p_*A \arrow[d] \\
p_*k_*k^!A \arrow[r] & p_*A \arrow[r] & p_*h_*h^*A.
\end{tikzcd}$$

The left vertical arrow is an equivalence by right base change for i along p. The middle arrow is the identity. Hence the right vertical arrow is also an equivalence; since $p_*h_* = j_*$ (because $ph = j$) and j_* is fully faithful, this gives $j^*p_*A \simeq h^*A$. □

2.2.4. The six-functor formalism for SH

Theorem 2.2.17 (Morel–Voevodsky [MV99]). *The stable motivic functor* $\mathsf{SH}\colon (\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}$ *satisfies the localization axiom.*

Theorem 2.2.18 (Ayoub [Ayo07], Cisinski–Déglise [CD19], Cnossen–Lenz–Linskens [CLL25]). *There is an essentially unique lax symmetric monoidal extension making the following diagram commute:*

$$\begin{tikzcd}
(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}})^{\mathrm{op}} \arrow[r, "\mathsf{SH}"] \arrow[d, hook] & \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}) \\
\mathsf{Span}_2(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}, E)^{\otimes}_{P,I} \arrow[ur, dashed] &
\end{tikzcd}$$

with E = morphisms locally of finite presentation, I = étale morphisms, P = proper morphisms. The 2-category $\mathsf{Span}_2(\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}, E)_{P,I}$ *has:*

- objects: *quasi-compact quasi-separated schemes;*
- 1-morphisms $X \to Z$: *spans*

$$\begin{tikzcd}
 & Y \arrow[dl, "f"'] \arrow[dr, "g"] & \\
X & & Z
\end{tikzcd}$$

  with f of finite presentation and g locally of finite presentation;

- 2-morphisms *between two such spans: diagrams*

$$\begin{tikzcd}
 & Y & \\
X & Y'' \arrow[u, "a"] \arrow[d, "b"'] & Z \\
 & Y' \arrow[ul] \arrow[ur] &
\end{tikzcd}$$

  with a proper and b étale.

In this extension, the ***exceptional pushforward*** *along $f \in E$ is given by $f_! = p_*\, i_\sharp$ for any factorization $f = p \circ i$ with i étale and p proper.*

***Remark* 2.2.19** (Structure of the proof). The proof is not a monolith; it decomposes into a formal step and a deep geometric step.

The *formal step* is the universal property of $\mathsf{Span}_2(-, E)^{\otimes}_{P,I}$ established by Cnossen–Lenz–Linskens [CLL25, Thm. 5.17]: given any lax symmetric monoidal functor $\mathsf{D}_0 \colon (\mathcal{C}^{\times})^{\mathrm{op}} \to \mathsf{Cat}^{\times}$ which is (I, P)-biadjointable and satisfies the projection formula, there is an essentially unique extension to $\mathsf{Span}_2(\mathcal{C}, E)^{\otimes}_{P,I}$. This step is purely 2-categorical and contains no algebro-geometric content.

The *geometric step* is to verify the input hypothesis, namely that SH is (I, P)-biadjointable. This breaks further into three ingredients:

- **Smooth/étale base change and the projection formula for $i_\sharp$:** these follow essentially from the construction of SH, since the smooth pushforward $i_\sharp$ on $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_-)$ is computed via the restriction along $\mathsf{Sm}_{/T} \to \mathsf{Sm}_{/S}$ for $i \colon T \to S$ étale, and this is compatible with base change at the level of presheaves.
- **Localization:** the recollement (i^*, j^*) for closed immersions i with open complement j. This is Theorem 2.2.17, due to Morel–Voevodsky [MV99].
- **Proper base change and the projection formula for p_*:** this is the deep input. Ayoub [Ayo07] proved proper base change for projective morphisms; combined with localization [MV99], this yields proper base change for all projective morphisms. Cisinski–Déglise [CD19] extended this to arbitrary proper morphisms using Chow's lemma and a Noetherian approximation argument.

Once all three ingredients are in hand, the full six-functor package on SH is obtained by invoking the universal property [CLL25]. The mixed Beck–Chevalley $i_\sharp p'_* \simeq p_* i'_\sharp$ is not an additional input: it follows from proper base change applied to a pullback square whose one edge is an étale morphism.

2.2.5. cdh descent for SH and KH

By Proposition 2.2.16 combined with Theorem 2.2.17 and the proper base change part of Remark 2.2.19, we obtain:

Corollary 2.2.20. *The functor* SH *is a cdh sheaf.*

2.2.6. The Drew–Gallauer universal property

With the six-functor formalism on SH now in hand, we return to the question advertised in the chapter introduction: in what precise sense is SH universal? The following theorem of Drew–Gallauer supplies the answer, and identifies the three axioms that single out SH among all reasonable $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant six-functor formalisms.

Theorem 2.2.21 (Drew–Gallauer [DG22]; cf. [Sch26, Theorem 11.1])**.** *Let k be a noetherian base ring with $\mathrm{Spec}(k)$ of finite Krull dimension, and let $\mathcal{C}$ be the category of separated finite-type k-schemes, equipped with I = open immersions and P = proper morphisms. Consider the category of presentable six-functor formalisms*

$$\mathsf{D} \colon \mathsf{Corr}(\mathcal{C}) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Pr}^L_{\mathrm{st}}$$

in which open immersions are cohomologically étale, proper maps are cohomologically proper, and which satisfy:

(i) ***Cohomological smoothness:*** *every smooth morphism is cohomologically smooth in* D*;*

(ii) ***Excision:*** *for any closed immersion $i \colon Z \hookrightarrow X$ with open complement $j \colon U \hookrightarrow X$, the sequence*

$$j_!\mathbf{1} \longrightarrow \mathbf{1} \longrightarrow i_*\mathbf{1}$$

is a fiber sequence in $\mathsf{D}(X)$*;*

(iii) ***$\mathbb{A}^1$-homology trivial:*** *for $\pi \colon \mathbb{A}^1 \to \mathrm{Spec}(k)$, the unit map $\mathbf{1} \to \pi_!\pi^!\mathbf{1}$ is an equivalence.*

This category has an initial object, and that initial object is the motivic six-functor formalism SH *of Morel–Voevodsky.*

The proof of [DG22] is constructive, and recovers the construction of SH given in §2.1: enforcing the existence of left adjoints $f_\sharp$ to smooth pullbacks gives the stable presheaf category $\mathsf{PShv}(\mathsf{Sm}_{/X}; \mathsf{Sp})$; excision implies Nisnevich descent and forces passage to $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_{/X}; \mathsf{Sp})$; triviality of $\mathbb{A}^1$-homology forces $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization, yielding $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_{/X}; \mathsf{Sp})$; finally, $\otimes$-inverting the Tate object yields SH. We refer the reader to [Sch26, §11] for a clean exposition of the proof sketch.

***Remark* 2.2.22** (Realizations of motives)**.** The power of Theorem 2.2.21 lies in its corollary: any other six-functor formalism on C satisfying axioms (1)–(3) automatically receives a unique symmetric monoidal functor from SH, called its **realization**. Concrete examples include:

- ℓ-adic étale cohomology $\mathsf{D}_{\text{ét}}(-, \mathbb{Z}_\ell)$, when ℓ is invertible on the base;
- Betti realization $\mathsf{D}(-(\mathbb{C}), \mathbb{Z})$, for $\mathbb{C}$-schemes;
- de Rham realization in characteristic 0.

Each yields a symmetric monoidal functor from SH and identifies the corresponding cohomology theory as a representable spectrum (the ℓ-adic, Betti, or de Rham realization spectrum). This is the modern conceptual explanation for why "every" reasonable cohomology theory of varieties admits motives in the first place.

2.3. Relating $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$

We now take up the comparison between $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and its naive stabilisation $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ that was advertised in the chapter introduction. An object $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ determines, and is determined by, its underlying graded-sheaf data $(E(j))_{j\in\mathbb{Z}}$ together with bonding equivalences $E(j) \simeq \underline{\mathrm{Map}}(\mathbb{T}_S, E(j+1))$. On the graded-sheaf side, the $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology theories coming from algebraic geometry — de Rham, Betti, étale, and so on — come equipped with additional structure: multiplicative products, first Chern classes, and the projective bundle formula. Our goal is to make the passage from such classical data to genuine motivic ring spectra precise.

The main result of the section is a symmetric monoidal equivalence

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \;\simeq\; \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$$

due to Bachmann–Elmanto–Morrow (Proposition 2.3.6), identifying graded sheaves with Chern classes and pbf with modules over a certain commutative algebra $\mathcal{P}'_S \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$. Composing with the forgetful functor then yields the **motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor**

$$H\colon \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \longrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S),$$

which sends classical $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant cohomology data to motivic ring spectra.

Our path to this equivalence is indirect. The tautological adjunction $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}} \dashv \omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ between graded sheaves and motivic spectra fails to be monoidal at the $\mathbb{E}_2$ level: the switch map on $\mathbb{T}_S \wedge \mathbb{T}_S$ is not homotopic to the identity. Passing to Bott-periodic modules builds in precisely the symmetry one needs, and the equivalence falls out cleanly.

2.3.1. Graded algebras and the projective bundle formula

Construction 2.3.1. Equip $\mathbb{Z}^\delta$ with its discrete groupoid structure, so that $\mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^\delta, C)$ acquires a symmetric monoidal structure via Day convolution with respect to the addition operation on $\mathbb{Z}$. Consider the square of commutative monoids in An:

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathbb{F} \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & \mathbb{N} \arrow[d] \\ \mathbb{S} \arrow[r] & \mathbb{Z} \end{tikzcd}$$

where the vertical maps are group completions and the horizontal maps are induced by π_0. Restriction along $\mathbb{F} \to \mathbb{N} \to \mathbb{Z}$ yields a lax symmetric monoidal forgetful functor

$$\mathrm{res}\colon \mathsf{Gr}(C) = \mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^\delta, C) \longrightarrow \mathsf{SSeq}(C).$$

Let $E^\star \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Gr}(\mathcal{C}))$ be a $\mathbb{Z}$-graded commutative algebra in $\mathcal{C}$, and let $c\colon T \to E^1$ be a morphism in $\mathcal{C}$ (a **Bott element**). By the universal property of Sym, the element c extends uniquely to a morphism

$$\mathrm{Sym}(T_{\mathrm{sym}}) \longrightarrow \mathrm{res}(E)$$

of commutative algebras in $\mathsf{SSeq}(\mathcal{C})$, making $\mathrm{res}(E)$ canonically into a commutative algebra in $\mathsf{Sp}_T^{\mathrm{lax}}(\mathcal{C})$. Moreover, if the resulting bonding maps

$$E^n \otimes T \xrightarrow{1\otimes c} E^n \otimes E^1 \longrightarrow E^{n+1}$$

have adjoints that are equivalences, then (E, c) lifts to a commutative algebra in $\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})$ with $\omega^{\infty-n}(E, c) \simeq E^n$ for all $n \in \mathbb{Z}$.

The motivic case

We now specialize to $\mathcal{C} = \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ with $T = \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S$, where $\mathbb{T}_S := (\mathbb{P}^1_S, \infty) \in \mathsf{H}_*(S)$ is the Tate object we defined in § 2.1, and Σ^∞ denotes the suspension functor $\Sigma^\infty\colon \mathsf{H}_*(S) \to \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$; a Bott element is then a morphism $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S \to E^1$.

Construction 2.3.2 (Q_S-modules and the projective bundle formula)**.** Let $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle \in \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ denote the graded sheaf concentrated in degree 1 with value $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S$, and set

$$Q_S \;:=\; \mathrm{Sym}\big(\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle\big) \;\in\; \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})\big).$$

One checks that $\sigma^\infty(Q_S) \simeq \mathrm{Sym}(\mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle) \in \mathsf{Gr}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, where on the right $\mathbb{T}_S$ stands for the image of $\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S$ under $\sigma^\infty\colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$, consistent with the notation of §2.1.

We therefore consider the category of Q_S-modules, for which we introduce the abbreviation

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}} \;:=\; \mathsf{Mod}_{Q_S}\big(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})\big).$$

Given $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}\big)$, the bonding maps of Construction 2.3.1 take the form

$$b^n\colon E^n \otimes \Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S \longrightarrow E^{n+1}, \qquad n \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

Passing to adjoints, these become

$$b^{n,\dagger}\colon E^n \longrightarrow \Omega_{\Sigma^\infty \mathbb{T}_S} E^{n+1} \;\simeq\; \mathrm{fib}\big(E^{n+1}(\mathbb{P}^1_-) \xrightarrow{\infty^*} E^{n+1}\big),$$

where ∞^* denotes restriction along the inclusion of the point at infinity. The requirement that every $b^{n,\dagger}$ is an equivalence is precisely the $\mathbb{P}^1$ **bundle formula** (pbf).

We write

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$$

for the full subcategory of Q_S-modules satisfying the $\mathbb{P}^1$ bundle formula.

The passage from such data to a genuine motivic spectrum is encoded in the functor H announced at the start of the section; we construct it in §2.3.4, after the Bott-periodic groundwork of §2.3.3 is in place.

2.3.2. The $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}} \dashv \omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ adjunction and periodization

To construct the Eilenberg–MacLane functor H, we approach the problem from the reverse direction: from a motivic spectrum $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$, extract a graded sheaf and ask when this graded sheaf lies in $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$.

By Proposition 2.1.13, for each $j \in \mathbb{Z}$, we can extract an $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant Nisnevich sheaf from E via the formula

$$E(j) = \mathrm{map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(M_S(-), E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j}).$$

***Warning* 2.3.3.** Our notation is different from [BEM25, 3.2], where they use the "$\mathbb{G}_m$-twist" and then define $E(j)$ as $\mathrm{map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}(M_S(-), E \otimes \mathbb{G}_m^{\otimes j})$. Our notation is close to the T-spectra we construct in § 2.1.3, and we believe that it is more natural.

Thus, we obtain

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \underset{\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}}{\overset{\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}}{\underset{\longleftarrow}{\overset{\longrightarrow}{\perp}}}} \mathsf{SH}(S).$$

where

$$\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}(E^\star) = \bigoplus_{n\in\mathbb{Z}} \sigma^\infty(E^n) \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes n}.$$

and thus

$$\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}(E)^n \simeq E(n) \simeq \omega^\infty(E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes n}).$$

Unfortunately, the functor $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ does not commute with pullback functors, and $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ is also not very multiplicative. Since $\mathsf{Gr}(\mathcal{C}) \simeq \mathsf{PShv}(\mathbb{Z}^\delta) \otimes \mathcal{C}$, the $\mathbb{E}_n$-monoidal structures on $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ are the same as $\mathbb{E}_n$-monoidal maps $\mathbb{Z} \to \mathcal{P}ic(\mathsf{SH}(S))$ sending 1 to $\mathbb{T}_S$. When $n = 1$, since $\mathbb{Z}$ is a free monoid on an invertible generator, there is such a canonical monoidal map and hence an induced monoidal structure on $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$. Thus, its right adjoint $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ inherits the desired natural lax monoidal structure, yielding

$$\mathsf{Alg}(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})) \leftarrow \mathsf{Alg}(\mathsf{SH}(S)).$$

But when $n = 2$, the existence of an $\mathbb{E}_2$-monoidal structure on $\sigma^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ requires the switch map on $\mathbb{T}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$ to be homotopic to the identity, which is not always true.

So, we need to consider another way.

Definition 2.3.4. For a commutative algebra $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, a **periodization** of E is the data of a compatible commutative algebra structure on $E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star} \in \mathsf{GrSH}(S)$. Let $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}$ denote the category of commutative algebras in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ equipped with a chosen periodization, with morphisms required to respect the periodization.

Now, we can find that $\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ upgrades to a functor (due to symmetric monoidality of ω^∞)

$$\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})) \leftarrow \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}.$$

But we still do not know whether $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}$ admits an interpretation intrinsic to $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ (here, $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}}$ is defined in terms of $\mathsf{GrSH}(S)$). We want to reinterpret periodized motivic ring spectra as commutative algebras over a certain commutative ring in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$.

For this, we need the notion of Bott-periodic modules.

2.3.3. Bott-periodic modules and the BEM equivalence

Definition 2.3.5 (Bott-periodic modules)**.** Let $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathcal{C})$ and let $\beta\colon T \to E$ be a morphism in $\mathcal{C}$ (the **Bott element**). The category of **β-periodic E-modules** is the monoidal Bousfield localization

$$P_\beta \mathsf{Mod}_E(\mathcal{C}) \subset \mathsf{Mod}_E(\mathcal{C})$$

obtained by inverting the map $\beta\colon T \otimes E \to E$.

Just like Construction 2.3.2, consider $\mathcal{P}_S := \mathrm{Sym}(\mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle) \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S))$. Write $\beta\colon \mathcal{P}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S\langle 1\rangle \to \mathcal{P}_S$, then we consider $P_\beta\mathcal{P}_S$. By [BH21, Lemma 12.1], $P_\beta\mathcal{P}_S$ is given by the telescope construction

$$\mathrm{colim}\left(\mathcal{P}_S \xrightarrow{\beta} \mathcal{P}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes -1}\langle -1\rangle \xrightarrow{\beta} \mathcal{P}_S \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes -2}\langle -2\rangle \xrightarrow{\beta} \cdots\right).$$

Now, we take $\mathcal{P}'_S := (P_\beta\mathcal{P}_S)^0$ to be the degree 0 piece. Note that in $\mathsf{GrSH}(S)$, we have an equivalence $E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star} \simeq E \otimes_{\mathcal{P}'_S} \mathrm{L}_\beta\mathcal{P}_S$.

Given a map $\mathcal{P}'_S \to E$ in $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, then $E \otimes_{\mathcal{P}'_S} \mathrm{L}_\beta\mathcal{P}_S$ defines the periodization of E. Conversely, given a periodization on some $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$, the unit map of E induces $\mathbb{T}_S \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S$, which then induces a map of commutative algebras $\mathcal{P}_S \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star}$, which then factors $\mathrm{L}_\beta\mathcal{P}_S \to E \otimes \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes\star}$, finally, passing to degree zero pieces defines the desired map $\mathcal{P}'_S \to E$.

Thus, we obtain an equivalence

$$\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathrm{per}} \simeq \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))_{\mathcal{P}'_S/}.$$

So, the right domain is $\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$.

Proposition 2.3.6 ([BEM25, Proposition 3.15]). *There is a monoidal equivalence $\omega_{\otimes}^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ filling the following commutative square of monoidal categories and lax monoidal functors:*

$$\begin{tikzcd} \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \arrow[d] & \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S)) \arrow[l, "\omega_{\otimes}^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}"'] \arrow[d] \\ \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp}) & \mathsf{SH}(S). \arrow[l, "\omega^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}"] \end{tikzcd}$$

Moreover, $\omega_{\otimes}^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$ upgrades to a symmetric monoidal equivalence. Consequently, the motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor H is the inverse of $\omega_{\otimes}^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$.

Proof. In fact, $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$ can be written as

$$P_v\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}$$

for $v\colon \mathcal{Q}_S \otimes \Sigma^\infty\mathbb{P}^1_S\langle 1\rangle \to \mathcal{Q}_S$. Since $\mathcal{Q}_S$ is the unit of $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}$, one can apply [Hoy20, Proposition 3.2] and then obtain

$$P_v\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}} \simeq P_v\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c}}[(\mathcal{Q}_S \otimes \Sigma^\infty\mathbb{P}^1_S\langle 1\rangle)^{-1}],$$

where the right hand side is the formal inversion of $\mathcal{Q}_S \otimes \Sigma^\infty\mathbb{P}^1_S\langle 1\rangle$ via Proposition 2.1.3. Since we have $\sigma^\infty(\mathcal{Q}_S) = \mathcal{P}_S$, we have

$$\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \simeq P_\beta\mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}_S}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S)) \simeq \mathsf{Mod}_{P_\beta\mathcal{P}_S}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S))$$

the second equivalence comes from [BH21, Lemma 12.1]. Thus, everything reduces to showing that

$$\mathsf{Mod}_{P_\beta\mathcal{P}_S}(\mathsf{GrSH}(S)) \simeq \mathsf{Mod}_{\mathcal{P}'_S}(\mathsf{SH}(S)),$$

but it follows from the discussion above. □

2.3.4. The motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor H

With Proposition 2.3.6 in hand, we can finally define H as the inverse of the equivalence $\omega_{\otimes}^{\infty,\mathrm{gr}}$.

Definition 2.3.7. The procedure above defines the **motivic Eilenberg–MacLane functor**

$$H\colon \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}} \to \mathsf{SH}(S).$$

"Traditional cohomology theories" of algebraic geometry which are $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant (e.g. algebraic de Rham cohomology, Betti cohomology) give rise to objects of $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}})$. Indeed, such cohomology theories have the following structure:

- they are a family of $\mathbb{A}^1$-invariant Nisnevich $\mathsf{D}(\mathbb{Z})$-valued sheaves $F(j)$, equipped with compatible multiplication maps $F(i) \otimes F(j) \to F(i+j)$;
- they admit a theory of Chern classes map $c_1\colon \Gamma_{\mathrm{Nis}}(-,\mathbb{G}_m)[1] \to F(1)$;
- they satisfy the projective bundle formula: for every smooth scheme $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ and $j \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $n \geq 1$, there exists an equivalence

$$\sum_{i=0}^{n} c_1(\mathcal{O}(1))^i\colon \bigoplus_{i=0}^{n} F(j-i)(X) \xrightarrow{\sim} F(j)(\mathbb{P}^n_X),$$

  when $n = 1$, it recovers the $\mathbb{P}^1$-bundle formula above.

From a modern point of view the multiplication maps assemble to form a commutative algebra structure in $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{D}(\mathbb{Z}))$ and then forgetting $\mathbb{Z}$-linear structure we obtain $F(\star) \in \mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{D}(\mathbb{Z}))$. Meanwhile, by restricting attention to the line bundle $\mathcal{O}(1) \in \mathrm{Pic}(\mathbb{P}^1_S)$, the first Chern class map induces a morphism $\Sigma^\infty\mathbb{P}^1_S \to F(1)$, as the composition

$$\Sigma^\infty\mathbb{P}^1_S \xrightarrow{[\mathcal{O}(1)]} \mathcal{P}ic \simeq \tau^{\leq 1}\Gamma_{\mathrm{Zar}}(-,\mathbb{G}_m)[1] \to F(1),$$

we thus indeed obtain an object of $\mathsf{GrShv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S,\mathsf{Sp})_{\mathrm{c,pbf}}$ and then corresponds to a motivic spectrum F.

2.3.5. Promoting Bott-periodic algebras to T-spectra

As a final application of the Bott-periodic framework, we record a general mechanism for promoting a Bott-periodic commutative algebra to a T-spectrum. This will be the key tool in the construction of motivic K-theory below.

Proposition 2.3.8 (Promotion to T-spectra). *Let $E \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathcal{C})$ and $\beta\colon T \to E$ be a Bott element. Then the suspension functor induces an equivalence*

$$\mathrm{L}_\beta \mathsf{Mod}_E(\mathcal{C}) \;\simeq\; \mathrm{L}_\beta \mathsf{Mod}_{\sigma^\infty(E)}\big(\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})\big).$$

Consequently, E admits an essentially unique promotion to a commutative algebra

$$\underline{E} \;\in\; \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{Sp}_T(\mathcal{C})\big) \qquad \text{with } \omega^{\infty-n}\underline{E} \simeq E \text{ for all } n \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

2.3.6. Example: the motivic K-theory spectrum KGL

We now apply the Bott-periodic construction (Proposition 2.3.8) to build the motivic K-theory spectrum $\mathrm{KGL}_S \in \mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{SH}(S))$.

Let $\mathrm{K}\colon \mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs,op}} \to \mathsf{Sp}$ denote non-connective algebraic K-theory. Define homotopy K-theory

$$\mathrm{KH}(X) \;:=\; \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}\mathrm{K}(X) \;=\; \mathrm{colim}_{[n]\in\mathbf{\Delta}^{\mathrm{op}}}\, \mathrm{K}\big(X \times \Delta^n\big).$$

Restricted to Sm_S, KH defines an object of $\mathsf{CAlg}(\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}))$.

The Bott element is the class

$$\beta \;=\; [\mathcal{O}(-1)] - [\mathcal{O}] \;\in\; \mathrm{fib}\big(\mathrm{K}(\mathbb{P}^1) \to \mathrm{K}(\infty)\big).$$

Using $\mathbb{T}_S \simeq \mathbb{P}^1_S/\{\infty\}$ this gives a morphism $\beta\colon \mathbb{T}_S \to \mathrm{KH}$ in $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$.

Definition 2.3.9 (KGL). The pair (KH, β) is Bott-periodic, and Proposition 2.3.8 promotes it to a commutative algebra

$$\mathrm{KGL}_S \;\in\; \mathsf{CAlg}\big(\mathsf{SH}(S)\big)$$

with $\omega_{\mathbb{T}}^{\infty-n}\mathrm{KGL}_S \simeq \mathrm{KH}$ for all $n \in \mathbb{Z}$, reflecting the Bott periodicity $\sigma\mathrm{KGL}_S \simeq \mathrm{KGL}_S$.

Proposition 2.3.10 (Base change for KGL). *For any morphism of schemes $f : Y \to X$, the natural map*

$$f^*\mathrm{KGL}_X \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{KGL}_Y$$

is an equivalence in $\mathsf{SH}(Y)$.

To show this, we need following proposition.

Proposition 2.3.11 (Bhatt–Lurie [EHK+20, Appendix A]). *The connective K-theory functor*

$$\mathrm{K}_{\geq 0}\colon \mathrm{CRing}_R \longrightarrow \mathsf{Sp}$$

is left Kan extended from its restriction to the subcategory SmRing_R of smooth R-algebras.

Proof of Proposition 2.3.11. It suffices to show that the rank-n vector bundle stack $\mathsf{Vect}_n : \mathrm{CRing}_R \to \mathsf{An}$ is left Kan extended from SmRing_R. A presheaf is left Kan extended from a subcategory iff it is a colimit of representables from that subcategory. Consider the chain of morphisms of stacks

$$\coprod_k U_{n,k} \longrightarrow \coprod_k \mathsf{Gr}_n(\mathbb{A}^k) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Vect}_n,$$

where Gr_n encodes affine bundles, while $U_{n,k}$ encodes smooth affine bundles. On affine schemes, the first map is surjective: every vector bundle can be embedded into trivial vector bundle. So this map is an effective epimorphism, and we may write Vect_n as the colimit of the Čech-nerve of this composite. But this Cech-nerve consists of disjoint unions of smooth affines, which are representables.. □

Proof of Proposition 2.3.10. By Proposition 2.3.11, $\mathrm{K}_{\geq 0}$ is left Kan extended from smooth affine algebras; the same holds for KH after $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization. Left Kan extension is automatically compatible with base change, so $f^*\mathrm{KH}_X \simeq \mathrm{KH}_Y$. Since the Bott element is also natural, the Bott-periodic construction (Proposition 2.3.8) gives $f^*\mathrm{KGL}_X \simeq \mathrm{KGL}_Y$. □

Corollary 2.3.12 (Cisinski). *The presheaf* KH *is a cdh sheaf on* $\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$.

Proof. By Corollary 2.2.20, SH is a cdh sheaf on $\mathsf{Sch}^{\mathrm{qcqs}}$. Combined with Proposition 2.3.10, this means that the assignment $X \mapsto \mathrm{KGL}_X \in \mathsf{SH}(X)$ is itself a cdh-local section of the cocartesian fibration $\int \mathsf{SH}$. Taking mapping anima out of the unit yields

$$\mathrm{KH}(X) \;\simeq\; \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(X)}(\mathbf{1}, \mathrm{KGL}_X),$$

which inherits cdh descent. □

2.3.7. The homotopy t-structure

We end this section with the homotopy t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ and, over a base field, its bigraded characterization in the sense of Morel. We follow [BH21, Appendix B].

In $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ there are two gradings: the **simplicial grading** (given by suspension) and the **Tate grading** (given by tensoring with $\mathbb{G}_m$). Recall from §1.4.2 that $\Sigma^{p,q} = (S^1)^{\wedge(p-q)} \wedge \mathbb{G}_m^{\wedge q}$; an object of simplicial degree a and Tate degree b is therefore $\Sigma^{a+b,b}$.

Notation 2.3.13. Let $I \subset \mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{Z}$ be a subset, where $(i,j) \in I$ represents the bidegree (simplicial, Tate). We denote by $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$ the full subcategory of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ generated under colimits and extensions by

$$\{\, \Sigma^{i+j,j} M_S(X) \mid X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S,\ (i,j) \in I \,\}.$$

Since $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is presentable stable and the generating family above is small, [Lur17, Proposition 1.4.4.11] implies that $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$ is the connective part of an accessible t-structure on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$. We denote the corresponding coconnective part by $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{<I}$, consisting of all $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ such that $\mathrm{Map}(F, E) \simeq *$ for every $F \in \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq I}$.

Different choices of I produce different t-structures adapted to different purposes. Among them, one is distinguished by its role in Morel's work [Mor05] on the stable $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity theorems.

Definition 2.3.14 (Homotopy t-structure). The **homotopy t-structure** on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is the t-structure determined by $I = \{0\} \times \mathbb{Z}$. We write $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq 0} := \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \{0\}\times\mathbb{Z}}$, and more generally $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d} := \mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \{d\}\times\mathbb{Z}}$ for $d \in \mathbb{Z}$. We denote by $\tau_{\geq d}$ the right adjoint to $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and by $\tau_{<d}$ the left adjoint to $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{<d} \hookrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$.

Unpacking the notation, $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq d}$ is the full subcategory generated under colimits and extensions by the objects $\Sigma^{d+j,j} M_S(X)$ with $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ and $j \in \mathbb{Z}$.

Over a base field, this t-structure admits a clean description in terms of bigraded homotopy sheaves.

Definition 2.3.15 (Bigraded homotopy sheaves). For $E \in \mathsf{SH}(S)$ and integers $i, j \in \mathbb{Z}$, the **(i,j)-th homotopy sheaf** of E is the Nisnevich sheaf $\pi_{i,j}(E)$ associated with the presheaf

$$X \longmapsto \pi_0 \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}\big(\Sigma^{i,j} M_S(X),\, E\big).$$

We also write

$$\pi_i(E)_j := \pi_0 \mathrm{Map}_{\mathsf{SH}(S)}\big(\Sigma^{i,0} M_S(-),\, \Sigma^{j,j} E\big) = \pi_{i-j,-j}(E).$$

By [Mor03, Proposition 5.1.14], the family $\{\pi_{i,j}\}_{i,j\in\mathbb{Z}}$ is jointly conservative on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$: a morphism in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ is an equivalence if and only if it induces isomorphisms on all bigraded homotopy sheaves.

Morel uses this conservativity to define, for $S = \mathrm{Spec}\, k$ the spectrum of a field, a t-structure $\mathcal{T}$ on $\mathsf{SH}(k)$ by

$$\mathcal{T}_{\geq d} := \{E \in \mathsf{SH}(k) \mid \pi_{i,j}(E) = 0,\ \forall\, i - j < d\},$$
$$\mathcal{T}_{\leq d} := \{E \in \mathsf{SH}(k) \mid \pi_{i,j}(E) = 0,\ \forall\, i - j > d\}.$$

It follows from a theorem of Hoyois that this t-structure coincides with the one of Definition 2.3.14:

Proposition 2.3.16 ([Hoy13, Theorem 2.3]). *Let k be a field and $E \in \mathsf{SH}(k)$. Then:*

(i) $E \in \mathsf{SH}(k)_{\geq d}$ *if and only if* $\pi_{i,j}(E) = 0$ *for all* $i - j < d$.

(ii) $E \in \mathsf{SH}(k)_{\leq d}$ *if and only if* $\pi_{i,j}(E) = 0$ *for all* $i - j > d$.

We now turn to the corresponding picture on the unstable side. Recall the adjunction

$$\sigma^\infty \colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \rightleftarrows \mathsf{SH}(S) \colon \omega^\infty$$

introduced in §2.1.4. On the left-hand side there is a natural Postnikov t-structure, and we describe how σ^∞ compares the two.

Definition 2.3.17 (Postnikov t-structure). The **Postnikov t-structure** on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ has connective part

$$\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq 0} := \left\{ F \,\middle|\, \pi_i(F) = 0 \text{ as Nisnevich sheaves for all } i < 0 \right\},$$

where $\pi_i(F)$ denotes the Nisnevich sheafification of the presheaf $X \mapsto \pi_i F(X)$. Equivalently, $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq 0}$ is the subcategory generated under colimits and extensions by $\{\Sigma^\infty_+ X[n] \mid X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S,\ n \geq 0\}$.

The $\mathbb{A}^1$-localized category $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ inherits a t-structure with the same definition on homotopy sheaves, and with connective part generated by $\{\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\Sigma^\infty_+ X[n]) \mid X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S,\ n \geq 0\}$. We refer to this as the Postnikov t-structure on $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})$ as well.

The two sides are connected by σ^∞:

Proposition 2.3.18. *The functor* $\sigma^\infty \colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$ *is right t-exact from the Postnikov t-structure to the homotopy t-structure.*

Proof. As a left adjoint, σ^∞ preserves colimits; being a functor of stable categories, it also preserves extensions. It therefore suffices to check the inclusion on the generators of $\mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq 0}$. Their images under σ^∞ are

$$\sigma^\infty\big(\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}(\Sigma^\infty_+ X[n])\big) = M_S(X)[n] \qquad (n \geq 0,\ X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S).$$

The object $M_S(X) = \Sigma^{0,0} M_S(X)$ is a generator of $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq 0}$ by Definition 2.3.14 (take $j = 0$), and $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq 0}$ is closed under positive shifts. □

While Proposition 2.3.18 is formal once the definitions are set up, the situation on the other side of the adjunction—namely how $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ affects Postnikov connectivity—is considerably more subtle. This is the content of Morel's celebrated $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity theorem and its generalizations. Recall from §2.2.2 the definition of the valuative dimension $\mathrm{v.dim}(S)$.

Theorem 2.3.19 (Shifted stable $\mathbb{A}^1$-connectivity, [BK25], [Mor05]). *Let S be a qcqs scheme with $d := \mathrm{v.dim}(S) < \infty$. For every integer n and every $F \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq n}$, the $\mathbb{A}^1$-localization satisfies*

$$\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} F \in \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp})_{\geq n-d}.$$

In particular, $\mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1}$ loses at most d degrees of connectivity, and is t-exact when S is the spectrum of a field.

Combining Proposition 2.3.18 with Theorem 2.3.19, one sees that the composite

$$\sigma^\infty \circ \mathrm{L}_{\mathbb{A}^1} \colon \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S, \mathsf{Sp}) \longrightarrow \mathsf{SH}(S)$$

sends the n-connective part of the Postnikov t-structure into the $(n-d)$-connective part of the homotopy t-structure, and is t-exact over a field.

2.4. Slice filtration and $\mathbb{Z}(\star)^{\mathbb{A}^1}$

We next discuss Voevodsky's slice filtration on $\mathsf{SH}(S)$.

2.4.1. Recollection of filtrations

Definition 2.4.1. Let C be a category. The category of **(decreasing) filtrations** $\mathsf{Fil}(C)$ is defined to be

$$\mathsf{Fil}(C) := \mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}, C).$$

The category of **increasing filtrations** is defined similarly, with $\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}$ replaced by $\mathbb{Z}$.

Intuitively, a filtration $F^\star$ looks like a sequence

$$\cdots \longrightarrow F^{s+1} \longrightarrow F^s \longrightarrow F^{s-1} \longrightarrow \cdots$$

The constant-filtration functor $C \to \mathsf{Fil}(C)$ is fully faithful and exhibits C as a full subcategory of $\mathsf{Fil}(C)$.

Definition 2.4.2. Let C be a category. A **filtration on an object** $X \in C$ is a filtration $F^\star$ together with a map $F^\star \to X$ of filtrations (regarding X as a constant filtration).

More generally, let $\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}} \cup \{-\infty\}$ denote the poset obtained from $\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}$ by adjoining an object $-\infty$ together with a unique morphism $n \to -\infty$ for every $n \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then the **category of pairs** $(F^\star \to X)$ **of filtrations on objects of** C is the functor category $\mathsf{Fun}(\mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}} \cup \{-\infty\}, C)$.

The picture to keep in mind is the diagram

$$\begin{tikzcd}
\cdots \arrow[r] & F^{s+1} \arrow[r] \arrow[dr] & F^s \arrow[r] \arrow[d] & F^{s-1} \arrow[r] \arrow[dl] & \cdots \\
& & X. &
\end{tikzcd}$$

Definition 2.4.3. Let C be a category.

- A filtration $F^\star$ on X is called **exhaustive** if the canonical map $\operatorname{colim}_{s \in \mathbb{Z}^{\mathrm{op}}} F^s \to X$ is an equivalence.
- A filtration $F^\star$ is called **complete** if $F^\infty := \lim_s F^s \simeq 0$.

Definition 2.4.4. Let C be a category with a terminal object $*$ that admits cofibers, and let $F^\star \in \mathsf{Fil}(C)$ be a filtration. For $i \in \mathbb{Z}$, the ***i*-th associated graded piece** is

$$\mathrm{gr}^i_F = \operatorname{cofib}\left(F^{i+1} \to F^i\right).$$

The associated graded functor is denoted $\mathrm{gr}^\star \colon \mathsf{Fil}(C) \to \mathsf{Gr}(C)$.

2.4.2. Effective motivic spectra and the slice filtration

In motivic homotopy theory, one filtration of particular interest is the slice filtration.

Definition 2.4.5. The category of **effective motivic spectra**

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S) \subseteq \mathsf{SH}(S)$$

is the smallest stable subcategory of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ which is closed under colimits and contains $M_S(X)[i]$ for all $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S$ and $i \in \mathbb{Z}$. More generally, for any $j \in \mathbb{Z}$, the category of ***j*-effective motivic spectra** is

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j) := \mathbb{T}_S^{\otimes j} \otimes \mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S).$$

By construction, $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$ coincides with $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \mathbb{Z}\times\{0\}}$ in the sense of Notation 2.3.13, and more generally $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)(j)$ coincides with $\mathsf{SH}(S)_{\geq \mathbb{Z}\times\{j\}}$. The subcategory $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)$ is closed under the tensor product of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$, and hence inherits a presentably symmetric monoidal structure.

TODO : Introduce very effective motivic spectra $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S)$ as the t-structure connective part $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S)_{\geq 0}$, or equivalently the subcategory of $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ generated under colimits and extensions by $\{M_S(X) \mid X \in \mathsf{Sm}_S\}$ (i.e., $I = \{(0,0)\}$ in Notation 2.3.13). Motivate the definition via the classical analogy: in classical stable homotopy theory, $\mathsf{Sp}_{\geq 0} \simeq \mathsf{CMon}^{\mathrm{gp}}(\mathsf{An})$ (grouplike $\mathbb{E}_\infty$-spaces), and stabilization yields $\mathsf{Sp} \simeq \mathsf{Sp}(\mathsf{An})$. The motivic recognition principle upgrades this to: $\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{veff}}(S) \simeq \mathsf{Shv}^{\mathrm{fr}}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Sm}_S)^{\mathrm{gp}}$, with stabilization giving Theorem 3.2.1. Framed correspondences $\mathsf{Corr}^{\mathrm{fr}}$ play the role that finite sets (via Σ^∞_+) play classically. Introduce the slice filtration $\cdots \to f_{q+1} \to f_q \to \cdots \to \mathbf{1}$ where $f_q = \tau^{\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}(q)}}_{\geq 0}$ or similar.

2.5. Low weights

This section is the script of my talk in the Oberseminar.

2.6. Orientation and formal group laws

2.7. The motivic Thom spectra MGL

Chapter 3.

Framed Correspondences and Motivic Recognition Principle

The recognition principle in ordinary homotopy theory and motivic version.

3.1. Framed correspondences

3.2. Motivic infinite loop space machine

Theorem 3.2.1 (Motivic recognition principle[EHK+21],[Hoy21]). *The functor*

$$\mathsf{SH}^{\mathrm{eff}}(S) \longrightarrow \mathsf{Shv}_{\mathrm{Nis},\mathbb{A}^1}(\mathsf{Corr}^{\mathrm{fr}}(\mathsf{Sm}_S), \mathsf{Sp})$$

is an equivalence between symmetric monoidal categories.

Sketch of the proof.

Appendix A.

Norms on Motivic (Pre)spectra

This appendix collects the norm-functor construction of Bachmann–Hoyois, which was previewed in Chapter 1 (see Remark 1.0.2) and underlies the multiplicative structure on motivic homotopy theory used at several points in Chapter 2.

We close the chapter by sketching the construction of **norm functors** due to Bachmann–Hoyois [BH21]. These provide additional multiplicative structure on motivic homotopy theory and play a central role in the theory of motivic spectra developed in Chapter 2.

A.1. Motivation and statement

For a finite locally free morphism $p\colon T \to S$ in classical algebraic geometry, there is the **Weil restriction** $\mathrm{R}_p\colon \mathsf{Sm}_T \to \mathsf{Sm}_S$, right adjoint to pullback $p^*\colon \mathsf{Sm}_S \to \mathsf{Sm}_T$, characterized by

$$\mathrm{Hom}_S(Y, \mathrm{R}_p X) \;\simeq\; \mathrm{Hom}_T(Y \times_S T, X).$$

In the pointed setting, Weil restriction extends to a symmetric monoidal functor $p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{Sm}_{T,+} \to \mathsf{Sm}_{S,+}$ (with respect to the smash product). The core question of [BH21] is: can $p_\otimes$ be extended to motivic homotopy theory?

Theorem A.1.1 (Bachmann–Hoyois [BH21, Theorems 3.3, 4.1]). *Let $p\colon T \to S$ be a finite locally free, universally open morphism. Then there exists a symmetric monoidal functor*

$$p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{H}_*(T) \longrightarrow \mathsf{H}_*(S)$$

satisfying:

(i) $p_\otimes$ preserves sifted colimits;

(ii) $p_\otimes(X_+) \simeq (\mathrm{R}_p X)_+$ for $X \in \mathsf{Sm}_T$;

(iii) if $T = S^{\sqcup n}$ and p is the fold map, then $p_\otimes$ is the n-fold smash product;

(iv) if p is moreover finite étale, $p_\otimes$ extends to a symmetric monoidal functor $p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{SH}(T) \to \mathsf{SH}(S)$.

***Remark* A.1.2** (Universal property of $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$). The proof of Theorem A.1.1 factors the construction through the universal sequence

$$\mathsf{Sm}_{T,+} \xrightarrow{(1)} \mathcal{P}_\Sigma(\mathsf{Sm}_T)_* \xrightarrow{(2)} \mathsf{H}_*(T) \xrightarrow{(3)} \mathsf{SH}(T).$$

Each step is a universal construction in $\mathrm{CAlg}(\mathsf{Cat}^{\mathrm{sift}})$ (presentably symmetric monoidal categories with sifted colimits). Consequently, the symmetric monoidal $p_\otimes\colon \mathsf{Sm}_{T,+} \to \mathsf{Sm}_{S,+}$ from Weil restriction has at most one sifted-colimit-preserving symmetric monoidal extension at each stage:

(i) the extension to $\mathcal{P}_\Sigma$ is unconditional;

(ii) the extension to H_* holds iff $p_\otimes$ preserves Nisnevich and $\mathbb{A}^1$ equivalences (which is the case for finite locally free universally open p);

(iii) the extension to SH holds iff $p_\otimes(\mathbb{P}^1_{T,+})$ is $\otimes$-invertible in $\mathsf{SH}(S)$ (which is the case for finite étale p).

This is a paradigmatic example of how the universal-property approach to motivic homotopy theory pays off: a hard "can we extend?" question reduces to checking elementary preservation properties.

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